Last and First Principles

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That Uncanny Green

CH36101-01

A silent afternoon. Enigma sits at his desk, trying to picture a field of grass.

But something else always pushes its way in—something bitter, something that tastes of rust. After several failed attempts, he pulls open the drawer and looks at what's inside.

A pistol.

A Luger P08. Practical for self-defense. A precise, purely scientific creation.

Enigma: Greta Hofmann.

He says the name quietly.

Enigma: Those who aren't taken by the "Storm"—where do they go when they die?

Enigma: I'd like to verify it for myself.

Cemetery

???: ... Never afraid of sacrifice, she followed her own path ...

???: ... and her fearlessness and perseverance ultimately ...

???: Ms. Marcus.

Marcus: Oh, you've arrived.

The young investigator lowers her head. A moment later, she manages a slightly easier expression.

Marcus: It's good to see you, Ms. Semmelweis.

Semmelweis glances at the papers in Marcus's hand. They're crumpled, and near where the ink has smeared, new letters have been neatly filled in.

Semmelweis: Relax. Everything will go smoothly.

Semmelweis: Where are the others?

Marcus: The Foundation's memorial ceremony has already ended. It was solemn. Almost everyone came to express their condolences. They just all had to get back to their work.

Semmelweis: Well, at least this cemetery will always remain open.

Semmelweis: I was more so wondering about those colleagues you're familiar with. Ms. Kakania, for example? I thought she'd be accompanying you.

Marcus: She had to go through a few more rounds of inquiries, so she couldn't make it. She did send a bouquet of flowers, though.

Marcus: It was just like the one you brought: a beautifully arranged bouquet of white chrysanthemums.

Semmelweis nods and surveys the figures scattered around them.

Semmelweis: And Enigma? Where's he gone off to? Weren't they each other's only family?

Semmelweis: I heard he was the one who pushed for the "Hofmann Knot" name. Rather admirable, if you ask me.

Semmelweis: But now, at that very sister's funeral, our Mr. Adler is nowhere to be found.

Marcus: A few days ago, Mr. Enigma helped me sort through Madam Hofmann's possessions.

Marcus: Then he left all in a hurry.

Marcus: Later, I received word from Laplace that he'd barred the door to his office.

Semmelweis: Hah. So he's chosen escapism, then.

The conversation ends there.

He, the two of them, and all the rest gathered here are little more than acquaintances to one another.

Familiar only in their mourning.

Marcus: ...

At last, Marcus speaks again.

Marcus: There was a mailing list among Madam Hofmann's possessions.

Marcus: On the train to Vienna, she asked me a question, hoping I could "read" its answer.

Hofmann: "What is the best way for someone to defend themselves if they cannot use arcane skills?"

Marcus: I read the answer she expected. She asked because she was preparing a gift.

The words fly out of her like fired bullets.

What a rare thing, the chance to ease unbearable grief simply by sharing it.

Marcus: Mr. Enigma packed the list, her documents, her ID badge, and her diary into a box. Madam Hofmann's entire life ... reduced to a tiny box.

Marcus: Then he stopped. And he asked me—

Enigma: Where do you think Greta has gone?

The ink on the paper in her hand starts to run again.

Marcus: "Where has she gone? Heaven? Hell? Has this 'Storm' washed them away too?"

Marcus: "Those who aren't lost to the 'Storm'—where do they go?"

Marcus: Will I see her again someday? Will all of us, any of us, see her again?

Marcus: If only I'd known earlier that the gift she was preparing was a birthday present for him, then instead of taking care of me and celebrating my first day as a Foundation Investigator, she could have ...

Marcus: If only my arcane skill were more useful! If only I'd read what would happen on that stage!

Marcus: If only the future were written out as words on a page!

Semmelweis says nothing. She only raises her hand gently.

But before that touch can reach her, Marcus draws a deep breath and forces her "what ifs" back down.

There is nowhere to turn for answers. No point in blaming herself. What's done is done.

Marcus: ...

Marcus: I told him I hoped Madam Hofmann had gone somewhere with no "Storm" and started a new life, even if that means we'll never see her again.

Marcus: In the end, he said he needed to think about my answer. He hasn't left his room since.

Marcus: I can understand that. I don't want to be here either. But I have to, because I want people to know that they don't need to worry about me anymore.

Marcus: Escapism is a natural reaction to grief. Just because you don't want to face it doesn't mean you're heartless, don't you think?

She waits almost stubbornly for an answer.

Semmelweis glances toward the distant grave and smiles softly.

Semmelweis: Look at you saying all that without stammering. You see? There's no need to worry.

Marcus: ...?

Marcus: S-Sorry. I-I shouldn't have suddenly ...

Semmelweis: No, you're right. Everyone handles grief differently.

Semmelweis: Let's go. I'd like to hear how your training is going. I'm sure Greta would be proud of how much her little apprentice has grown.

Marcus: Alright, Ms. Semmelweis.

She nods solemnly.

They pass through the gathering crowd and stand before the grave.

Marcus: *deep breath*

She gazes at the small box in the hole. Everything suddenly feels unreal.

She desperately wishes it were unreal, just some nightmare her mind conjured under pressure.

But every book has an end.

It's time to turn the page.

Marcus: Madam Hofmann was an exemplary Foundation Investigator, a dependable teammate, and my dearest mentor.

Marcus: She never cowered in the face of sacrifice. She followed ...

A hand settles on her back. Semmelweis finishes the sentence for her.

Semmelweis: She followed her own path until the end ...

Marcus: ... pursuing the truth with a resolute heart.

Marcus: And, ultimately, it was her fearlessness and perseverance that brought us the knot that allows us to cross the "Storm."

That's why I have to cherish every chance to keep the story going.

Marcus: She inspired many, none more than myself. She gave me the courage to leave the Flannan Isles, allowing me to witness and read so many new things. So standing here, I vow ...

Marcus: To continue to seek what she sought, what we all seek! A world after 1999!

Because I want to see the world you believed in.

Marcus: I will persevere as she did. I will keep reading, keep writing, record every experience, every feeling!

Marcus: I ...

Marcus: ... will never forget what you've done for us. For me.

Revolve

CH36101-02

Laplace Hallway

???: Damn it, are you blind?!

Foundation Staff Member: Honestly, is there no code of conduct among you people? You're the one barreling down the hall!

Foundation Staff Member: Hold on, you're—

After spotting the bite mark-covered ID badge, he wisely swallows his words.

Foundation Staff Member: Researcher Medicine Pocket?

Medicine Pocket: Oh! Sweet! Looks like even the little minions at the Foundation have heard of me.

Medicine Pocket: I'm rushing to get a sample right now. If you're here for Ulrich, try that lab over there. If you're here for Enigma, check his office. If you're here for me, get lost! Better luck next time.

They glance past the staff member, interest suddenly piqued.

Medicine Pocket: Ooh, wait, let me guess! You suits can't take it anymore, so you're gonna shove a new director on us, right?

Medicine Pocket: Or maybe one of the oh-so-generous higher-ups has finally approved our application for a new lab?

Medicine Pocket: Oh, or maybe you're here to command us very obedient researchers to fix you up an ark? You know, like Noah?

Medicine Pocket: Well, here's an idea: how about you shelve all that and let us get back to our research on edible Picrasma extract? At worst, we'll get a taste of something sweet!

The staff member gives an awkward wave and quickens his pace, hoping to get out of this predicament as soon as possible.

Foundation Staff Member: That's a topic that requires a rigorous approval process and oversight from ... I-It's not within my power to decide!

Foundation Staff Member: I need to deliver these files to Mr. Enigma immediately. I won't take up any more of your time!

Medicine Pocket: Tsk.

They toss a small metal tube to the flustered staff member.

Foundation Staff Member: ...?

Medicine Pocket: Give him this, and make sure he eats it! My application's been sitting on his desk for 30 hours. Looks like the only way I'm gonna get through to him is if he experiences it for himself!

Medicine Pocket: If there's an emergency, just press the button on the wall. Not the red one.

Medicine Pocket doesn't wait for a response, disappearing around the next corner instead.

The staff member is left with nothing but a closed door in the distance.

Enigma: I see. You can follow the proper procedures to file a complaint against Researcher Medicine Pocket.

He tosses the metal tube to one side and grabs something off his desk.

A crumpled ball of paper drops neatly into the wastebasket by the staff member's feet.

Enigma: Their application has already been reviewed, the ever-generous assessor that I am.

Enigma: As for your request, based on the progress of our other projects, you can expect a response in about 69 business days.

Foundation Staff Member: This is an urgent matter, sir!

Enigma: I understand completely. It's a pity for us both that Laplace isn't a wish-granting machine.

Enigma: If it truly is as urgent as you say, put the documents on the pile to your left. Make sure not to touch anything else.

Foundation Staff Member: Then, when's the earliest—

Enigma: 52 business days.

Enigma: In principle, my department only accepts research assignments pertaining to the "Storm." And only the final results are delivered to us.

Enigma: The calculations and sample analyses you need will be handed off to other teams, but it's not like we have spare researchers just moseying around. And Laplace isn't the Foundation's personal calculator.

Enigma: If you have any objections or extenuating circumstances, you can take it up with our director.

Enigma: Ah, but of course, the position's still empty. I'm only standing in to manage the documents and affairs no one else cares to deal with. Looks like it'll be a tough job to find you a team.

Enigma: Close the door on your way out.

Foundation Staff Member: ...

To his surprise, the staff member doesn't argue. But he doesn't budge, either.

Enigma: Tch, you can move your own legs without your boss's orders, can't you? Get out.

???: I'm glad to see you're still full of vigor, Adler.

His head snaps up in surprise as a familiar figure steps inside.

Seeing who it is, he finally sets down his pen.

Enigma: Ah, if it isn't my old friend. What are you fetching for Constantine this time?

Enigma: I trust the last report you snatched was to your satisfaction? If anything else in these stacks of scrap paper strikes your fancy, then by all means, help yourself.

He extends an arm and pats the mountain of files beside him.

Z: That won't be necessary. Though, I'll be sure to visit again should the need arise.

Z: Mark, there are still some details regarding the proposed adjustment to field agent rations I'd like you to confirm.

Z: Mr. Ulrich and Ms. Simone have cleared a fifteen-minute block in their schedules. You'll find them in Meeting Room No. 3.

Foundation Staff Member: Very well.

The door closes.

Enigma: You knew of Ms. Simone's return today?

Enigma: Most assumed she retired to the Timekeeper's Suitcase along with Madam Lucy.

Enigma: Looks like the Foundation keeps as close an eye on Laplace as they do on Manus Vindictae.

He scoffs.

Enigma: Heh. Some might even say that mad scientists and fanatical arcanists aren't so different. Though the former does have the small advantage of providing a handy little invention here and there.

Z: Always thinking from a researcher's perspective, Adler.

Z: Every researcher wants an independent, undisturbed laboratory. A simple wish in theory, but difficult to implement in practice.

Enigma: Hm. I'm sure you didn't come all this way just to lecture me.

Enigma: What's the matter?

Z: I trust Ulrich has told you what transpired in Antarctica.

Z: Not long ago, we received reports from our field agent squads and investigators.

Z: This time, the "Storm" has brought us to the year 1920. And to a war that should no longer exist.

Enigma: The "Storm" is hardly a perfect formula, and historical records often contain inaccuracies. Even under our current theoretical models, arcanum maintains a degree of uncertainty and unknowability. A minor error such as this should come as no surprise to you.

He takes the stack of reports in Madam Z's hand nonetheless.

As he flips through its pages, his expression grows serious.

Enigma: Hm. An error of this magnitude doesn't follow any of our current models.

Enigma: This "Flood" has destroyed at least two-thirds of all our prior findings!

Z: Since the beginning, we've diligently tracked the occurrence frequency of the "Storm." We've also long gotten used to it abandoning any semblance of a pattern.

Enigma: Hah, because those who haven't "gotten used to it" are no longer with us.

A scornful laugh.

Z: It's never easy to have your world turned upside-down. For anyone.

Z: It's overwhelming at first, but the more you see it happen, the easier it is to accept. Of course, some still have their objections.

Z: There have been countless debates on whether we should prepare for war.

Enigma: Laplace is not an arsenal.

Z: Our more radical members believe that since research on the "Storm" will continue to be lost, we should divert our resources elsewhere.

Z: The LSCC has been without a director for a long time, and the arcanocentric society "Institutum Lorentz" has gone unchecked. There's reason to believe that this has impacted Laplace's research efficiency.

She studies Enigma's expression, knowing he's already figured out why she has come.

Z: So, to ensure our collaboration with Laplace continues to yield valuable results, the Foundation plans to dispatch a director of their own choosing.

Enigma: Absolutely not.

His clenched fist never comes down on the desk.

He stifles his anger. Rage won't help him now.

Z: I don't agree with the sentiment, nor do I believe the Foundation should assume complete control of Laplace.

Z: However, the reality is that—besides some perfect directing machine—the members will be the most easily persuaded if we appoint a human as director.

Z: Which is why I've come to you today.

Z: If, under your leadership, Laplace can produce a persuasive new discovery during this tumultuous period, it would help my cause immensely.

Z: Of course, no matter what, I'll continue to express my support for Laplace's independence to the Foundation.

Enigma looks at his old colleague. They worked together a long time ago, if only briefly.

Enigma: What exactly are you hoping to achieve with all this politicking? For Laplace to align itself with the Foundation, or with yourself?

Enigma: You don't seriously expect a group of scientists to spend their time strategizing these things like some kind of warlords pushing clay figurines around a sand table, do you?

Madam Z doesn't answer directly.

Z: I'd like you to continue your research on the toybox sent by Musae III. Investigate the source of its power and use its simulations to push out a report.

Z: Producing a final *Pre-Storm Protocol* will refute the accusations that the LSCC lacks risk management policies, and the core of the toybox may just provide the "new results" you need.

Enigma: I see your reasoning. But why are you telling me this? Surely you aren't offering your help simply out of the goodness of your heart.

Enigma: What exactly are your feelings toward Laplace nowadays? Nostalgia? Or some kind of scientific idealism?

Madam Z pauses. Then she brings up that old, often-discussed topic.

Z: I still believe we can reach the final theory, something all-encompassing that unifies the entire universe.

Enigma falters, then lets out a sigh.

Enigma: Well, in that, we've just been going in circles. In a decade, all we've managed is to return to the 11th dimension.

Z: Mm. But that doesn't mean all our past efforts have been meaningless.

She rises, cutting the conversation short.

Z: The Timekeeper hopes to understand the situation outside as soon as possible. Once you've arrived at a conclusion, please contact me immediately.

The door closes again.

Madam Z stands in the corridor, gazing up at the unfamiliar silver-white building.

Z: Can a scientist ...

Z: ... become a politician?

School Days

小径

String Theory 101

A philosopher from your homeland once said, "If we take a foot-long stick and cut it in half each day, we will never reach its end."
No, I'm not here to discuss calculus. I'd like to ask you this: Do you think a stick can truly be divided forever? If you reach the point where it can no longer be halved, what remains?
You might say it's some fundamental particle, but in my class, the correct answer is a string. Nature's most basic unit is not a particle but an incredibly tiny string. Divide a stick to its limit, and you'll find a string. Divide gold down to its limit, and you'll also find a string. Even the basic unit of gravity should be a string.
The entire world is made of strings vibrating at different frequencies in unseen, higher dimensions. They may seem insignificant, but they are everywhere.
Some pragmatists may laugh at you for taking this class. Why deal with a fantastical theory that has no experimental proof?
I am a human, but you are an arcanist. I hope you understand my pursuit of a perfect concept, Ms. Zhang.

The Answer at the Bottom

CH36101-03

???: There must be a theory that unifies everything in the universe.

???: Because every puzzle has a solution.

Lines form a framework, waiting for one letter to anchor the answer.

???: The world is like a crossword. If you follow the clues—

Enigma: Ugh.

Enigma: Damn it. Isn't it about time humanity evolved beyond sleep?

He shakes his head and fixes his gaze on the jumbled grid lines covering his desk.

Pushing the papers and files aside, he turns on the screen.

3 PM.

Enigma: It's only been six hours. Looks like the little biter's actually done some work in between destroying public property. Side effects have certainly lessened.

Enigma: Did I throw away the instruction manual? What did it say?

Enigma: Never mind. The lethal side effects have already been eliminated; the other symptoms don't matter.

He rummages under the papers for the metal tube and tips two colorful candies into his palm.

Enigma: I hope this helps.

Enigma: Toybox research, the Timekeeper's request, new results ... and Lorentz. Alright.

Enigma: As always, problems rarely come alone.

Enigma: But the more problems there are, the closer we are to the solution.

Ulrich: We need to stop creating more problems!

Ulrich slams his fist down on the desk in an attempt to end the chaotic discussion spiraling before him.

Unfortunately, in Laplace, shouting only invites a louder rebuttal.

Medicine Pocket: Then get rid of the approval system so we can all work in peace for a couple weeks! You know, spend our time actually experimenting instead of writing damn reports!

Medicine Pocket: That's our problem! I'm telling you, even if Enigma locked himself in that room for the next decade, he wouldn't get through them all!

Ulrich: Focus on the matter at hand, Researcher Medicine Pocket!

Ulrich: The toybox has been fixed for now, and the communication problems it caused have also disappeared. But we need to come up with a way to prevent any similar incidents in the future.

Ulrich: And it's crucial we figure out how it had such a widespread effect. We can't risk almost all of Laplace speaking in cipher again.

Ulrich: I, for one, believe it's related to the Storm Syndrome. But our research progress has been far too slow, so I need everyone—

Medicine Pocket: There you go again. You're gonna say that the "language disorder" interfered with our work, right?

Medicine Pocket: Well, let me make this clear: whether I use cipher or decimal or freaking latte art to communicate, it's not gonna stop me from doing what I want.

Medicine Pocket mimics Ulrich's tone, drawing out the words.

Medicine Pocket: Those emergency handbooks are only filling that tank of yours with useless, garbage data. Whatever happens, my advice is the same—

Medicine Pocket: Mind your own business and let us fend for ourselves!

Hissabeth: Hah, sounds like you've gotten over accidentally ordering Critter chow at the canteen. I suppose it is quite difficult to decipher a Tetris-based language, no?

Hissabeth: And no, we can't just "blow up the toybox," Medicine Pocket. As I said before, it cannot be destroyed through arcane nor scientific means. You should know when to quit.

Ulrich: Blow it up? Absolutely not!

The ferrofluid nearly bounces in the tank.

Ulrich: Adler already notified us that the Foundation is pressuring us to deliver persuasive research results!

Ulrich: This isn't the first time they've used our "laissez-faire attitude" as an excuse to attack Laplace. We need to use the toybox's simulations to create a reliable emergency protocol!

Medicine Pocket: Okay, I get you. We just need to submit something that'll shut them up.

Medicine Pocket: So, why don't you round up everyone who's been wasting research materials, hand them all "Lorentz" ID badges, and turn them over?

Hissabeth: I did hear the Foundation has been quite "lively" lately. As crowded and chaotic as the crystal structure of austenite, supposedly.

Ulrich: ...

Ulrich is clearly trying his best to hold it together. Eventually, the tremor in his voice module settles.

Ulrich: That's quite enough. Now, if you'd please return to today's topic.

Ulrich: Researcher Pointer, Researcher X. How are the results of your data analysis?

The two researchers have long grown accustomed to the lab's clamor. They know silence is the best way to keep out of it.

Pointer pushes a stack of files toward Ulrich.

Pointer: Here's my section. I've included a summary for the Timekeeper's perusal.

Pointer: In simple terms, the "Flood" has altered the characteristics of the "Storm."

Pointer: The vast majority of our past data has been rendered useless. Our most reliable models require multiple rounds of verification. Therefore, our current conclusions are for reference only.

Ulrich: This should be plenty. I'm confident we'll adapt to these new conditions very soon.

Everyone silently agrees.

Ulrich: Have we made any discoveries regarding the arcane fluctuations emanating from the toybox?

X: If we're only looking at the numbers, the magnitude of these arcane fluctuations far exceeds normal levels.

X: I also consulted all the arcanists I know with arcane skills related to language, words, or sound. None of them could find any manmade traces in the fluctuations.

X: I have two hypotheses. One: This toybox is a naturally occurring arcane object. And two: Its core holds a power beyond most arcanists' comprehension.

He pauses. Hesitation, perhaps?

X: I also have a personal theory. Mr. Ludwig's arcane fluctuations ...

Thud!

The meeting room door is thrown open, slamming it against the wall.

Everyone turns toward the figure that has just burst in.

???: Mr. Enigma.

Enigma: Door's unlocked.

The visitor pushes the door open and enters.

Enigma: I already reviewed your application last Wednesday, X.

Enigma: And you and Hissabeth can stop submitting those clinical trial applications for Medicine Pocket's project.

X: Oh, I have a friend ...

Enigma: Regulus is not an option, either. There isn't a hair on her body that doesn't scream "arcanist."

Enigma: I will handle this myself. After all, I was the one who questioned Medicine Pocket on the possibility of resuming research on the topic in the first place.

X: It's a compelling research direction. An antidote for Picrasma extract suitable for human consumption and a universally applicable, edible extract with energizing effects.

He delivers the long string of terms with neither a stumble nor a pause, as if reciting from a script.

X: There's no need for you to worry. I read the project proposal. Medicine Pocket already consulted me on a few issues.

Enigma: That proposal was supposed to be confidential. *sigh* Never mind, but we need to act like this research topic doesn't exist until it yields some results.

Enigma: You are all pureblood arcanists. You have a natural tolerance for Picrasma extract. But it's simply too dangerous to move straight on to pureblood humans.

Enigma: Well, I suppose it's about time my quarter-arcanist blood came in handy.

X: I understand, Mr. Enigma. I have no intention—nor the power, mind you—to interfere with anyone's decision.

X: But I did receive a document I think you should see.

Enigma: Of course you did. There's always more.

X: It's about the "language disorder" caused by the toybox's malfunction. I'm sure you're familiar with it.

X: Although the world outside has returned to normal, a lot of curious occurrences have appeared in the toybox. Allegedly, the behavior of its inhabitants has been becoming increasingly formulaic and unified.

X: Of course, these are Mr. Ulrich's words. I haven't seen it for myself.

X: The specifics are on top.

He hands over the document.

X: I read the whole thing. It's comprehensive. Exhaustive, even. It should be more than enough to submit to the Foundation.

X: But Ulrich isn't convinced it's persuasive enough, so he hasn't turned it in.

X: We all know how easy it is to fall down a research rabbit hole. He needs someone on the outside to step in and make a decision.

X: At least, that's what I think.

X: There's also the small matter of a waveform contaminating the toybox's arcane fluctuations—a waveform extremely similar to that of our dear Mr. Raven.

X: I've compared it. It's distinctly different from the other simulation data.

X delivers the last of his prepared lines.

And with that, the butterfly has flapped its wings.

He steps out and shuts the door behind him.

Enigma: Ulrich.

Enigma: Ulrich!

Ulrich: ...

Enigma: I'm trying to return this copy of your report that you "forgot."

Toybox User Manual

小径

Read Before Opening

Step 1: Swear you are more than six years old or at least no longer have a habit of putting toys in your mouth.

Step 2: Place the toybox upright on a firm surface, with my handsome faces facing up.

Step 3: Make sure no cats are around.

Step 4: Make sure you have at least one friend to play with—multiple personalities count as friends too!

Step 5: Chant this happy little incantation: "With arcanum comes endless imagination! The Musae Museum, right before your eyes!"

Musae III reserves the right to final interpretation of this product.

Aftermath

小径

/lo/ - I formatted the servers

0001 Anonymous No.00000001 ▸
The "language disorder" badly damaged our servers. Much of our historical data was corrupted into garbled text and couldn't be recovered. There was nothing I could do except format the servers.

0002 Anonymous No.00000012 ▸
So this is what wanting to turn back time feels like … I almost want to join Manus Vindictae.

0003 Anonymous No.00000038 ▸>>00000043
Whatever. A whole year's worth of my experimental data got turned into gibberish. How could things get any worse?

0004 Anonymous No.00000043 ▸
>>00000038
Becoming Enigma.

0005 Anonymous No.00000056 ▸>>00000067
What if we throw all the servers into the "Storm"? How likely are we to get a server from before the "language disorder"?

0006 Anonymous No.00000067 ▸
>>00000056
The data says the chance is so small that even an astronomer would ignore it. But if we made the "Storm" affect all of Laplace …

0007 Anonymous No.00000073 ▸
Someone's evil index has surpassed Medicine Pocket's. I've contacted security.

0008 Anonymous No.00000081 ▸>>00000083
What a disaster. You know, one hexadecimal John Titor is already enough trouble.

0009 Anonymous No.00000083 ▸>>00000090

>>00000081
I heard she spoke almost only English the whole time during the "language disorder."

0010 Anonymous No.00000090 ▸>>00000113
>>00000083
What?! Sweet Madam Lucy! Did that really happen?

0011 Anonymous No.00000113 ▸>>00000125
>>00000090
Maybe. Maybe not. Rumors about her are always like that.

0012 Anonymous No.00000125 ▸
>>00000113
I'd like to join Manus Vindictae too. It's honestly worth considering.

0013 Anonymous No.00000128 ▸
That's it, folks. Laplace is done for.

Portable Reality

CH36101-04

Forest, Toybox

A "professional" expedition team of one investigator and two researchers trudges through the woods.

Marcus: We've encountered more and more Critters since we entered this forest.

Enigma: At least we didn't come here for nothing.

Enigma: Hey, Ulrich. Don't forget our loot.

His fellow researcher stares at him incredulously.

Ulrich: "Loot"? Adler, are you seriously calling these supplies "loot"?

Ulrich: I didn't expect you of all people to start indulging in roleplay.

Enigma: I don't know what you're talking about.

Enigma: And you can save your energy for the journey. We still have a long way ahead of us.

Ulrich: ...

Sensing another argument brewing, Marcus cuts in.

Marcus: Mr. Enigma, Mr. Ulrich, perhaps we should hurry.

Marcus: So we can get there before the "language disorder" spreads to all of Laplace.

Enigma: Ah, good. At least someone in our party can put together a rational thought.

Marcus: According to Musae's map, we still have seven kilometers until we reach the toybox's depths.

Marcus: If we cross this Critter's territory, we'll save a third of the time it would take to go around—

Suddenly, a strange noise interrupts her.

Ulrich: Is that a Critter?

???: &%¥@ ... &*# ...

Enigma: No, it's an arcanist using Critter-Speech.

Enigma: Looks like another piece afflicted with the "language disorder."

Marcus stares at the arcanist and frowns.

Marcus: We're too far away. I can't make out what he's trying to say.

Marcus: Let's get closer. I may be able to "read" some useful information.

Marcus: Alright. Allow me.

The trek ends with a tall building peeking out from beyond the trees.

Marcus: Goodness, this really was a shortcut!

Enigma glances at her. Marcus is excitedly checking what's ahead, a far cry from that head-down figure he vaguely remembers.

Yes, the spitting image of a brave investigator. A mountaineer. A ...

Enigma: I'm very grateful for your help, Ms. Marcus. I wager we'd still be running in circles if you weren't here.

Ulrich: Indeed. If we can maintain this rate of progress ...

Ulrich: We'll be submitting an up-to-standard *Pre-Storm Protocol* very, very soon.

Enigma: Ulrich, why didn't you submit this copy of the *Pre-Storm Protocol*?

Ulrich: Half-finished products have no place in a conference, Adler.

Faced with the substitute director's aggressive interrogation, Ulrich only watches as the file is slammed onto the desk.

Ulrich: It simply isn't persuasive enough. The toybox's "Storm" simulation still poses some problems that require solving.

Medicine Pocket: Am I hearing this right, blob-for-brains? You're telling me you've already finished the damn thing, but you thought you'd play us all for laughs for a while?

Medicine Pocket: Urgh, just turn it in, damn it! Shut those checkered chumps up!

Ulrich: As I said, there are still some problems that haven't—

Enigma: Ulrich, you're slipping into the mindset of a "creator."

Enigma: They're simulated data. There's no need for your "humanitarian care."

Ulrich: And YOUR biases are showing, Adler.

Ulrich: As you'll recall from your encounters with the many familiar faces in the toybox, the pieces there are not objectively different from their real-world counterparts.

Familiar faces.

No. None of this is real.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: They're just pieces of data. Parts of a simulation.

Enigma: You shut yourself in your labs, in the toybox, calculating all day. And for what?

Enigma: If you all keep playing "delusional genius" and continue to ignore the problems Laplace is facing, soon it will be out of our hands.

Enigma: This isn't the toybox. There are no resets.

A brief silence falls over the meeting room. Then, the researchers catch on to a certain keyword.

Pointer: It's true, Adler. With every new era brought by the "Storm," the Foundation has only tightened their policies. Perhaps to an extreme.

Pointer: However, they need Laplace's research results. They need our innovation, our inventions.

Pointer: The Foundation doesn't view us as an enemy.

Medicine Pocket: Exactly. I seriously don't get you guys. It's not like it'll affect us, so quit wasting our time with all these meetings!

Medicine Pocket: So what if Laplace loses its independence?

Ulrich: Adler, we can't properly discuss the issue if you don't explain what's making you so apprehensive.

Enigma's mouth opens. A habitual scoff slips out before any words can.

Enigma: Hah. If the Foundation passes their "Storm" personnel reform, do you really think you'll be able to continue your research freely?

Enigma: Laplace is this close to being completely subsumed by the Foundation! When that happens, where do you think our inventions are going to be used?

Enigma: Don't tell me that none of you have ever considered—

Hissabeth: Oh la la, no wonder they called you Enigma! If you've got some insider information, just tell us already!

The substitute director draws a deep breath.

Office, Foundation

Constantine: Adler Hofmann, you've arrived. Please, sit.

Enigma: No need. I'm not here to chat.

Constantine: Fine by me. Then allow me to move on to the subject: how's your progress on the "Storm" contingency plan the Foundation requested?

Enigma waves the question away impatiently.

Enigma: Get to the point.

Constantine: I had planned on some small talk, but I'll get right to it if you wish.

She leans back in her chair.

Constantine: If you assume the position of Laplace's next director, I can promise that the Foundation will not significantly interfere with the LSCC's regular operations.

Enigma: On the condition I obey your every word?

Constantine: Quite the opposite. Everything will be in your hands, to do with as you see fit.

Enigma: Then I would choose to keep things the way they are.

Enigma: And there are plenty of more outstanding—more rational—members who could take on the responsibility.

Enigma: Take Ulrich, the leader of the "Storm" Research Group, for example. Or Pointer—she did remarkable work on developing the teleport disk. Among any number of others.

Constantine: Mr. Adler, I'm afraid you've missed a crucial point.

Constantine: Although Committee Member Irinei is the one pushing for the "Storm" personnel reform, appointing you as the director of Laplace is not his intention.

Enigma: It's yours, isn't it, Madam Constantine?

Constantine: You see, a keen mind is a key prerequisite to becoming director.

Constantine: The core of the issue isn't how the Foundation presents its final decision to the outside world, but who we present. And what we need is a "human." A stable, persuasive, uncontroversial human.

Constantine: When all is said and done, the Foundation's objective remains the same. We only wish to do all we can to brave the "Storm."

Constantine: In this regard, you are the best choice, Mr. Adler.

Enigma: Your best choice was forced to retire in the Timekeeper's Suitcase.

Constantine: Ah, yes. Madam Lucy has certainly been enjoying a comfortable vacation.

Maintaining her smile, Constantine steers the conversation in another direction.

Constantine: But let's not dwell on that. There's something else I wanted to tell you. Something interesting—to be kept to yourself for the time being, of course. It's a research topic we haven't yet revealed to Laplace.

Enigma: ...!

Constantine: As you're well aware, for many years we've been searching for a method to bring back those reversed in the "Storm."

Constantine: Well, the Foundation has discovered a feasible theory: if we can inject a person's past memories into a suitable body, then we can restore those who were lost.

Constantine: All those years ago, a special candidate helped us in the first stages of this experiment. And now, we're finally starting to see results.

Constantine: To this end, we hope to acquire help from Laplace.

Passersby

CH36101-05

Medicine Pocket: Go on, spit it out!

Medicine Pocket: Or have all those long-winded administrative tasks totally destroyed your ability to get to the point?

Ulrich: You know something, don't you, Adler?

Everyone waits for Enigma to speak, but all they get is a room full of puzzled looks.

Enigma: ...

No matter how much he despises Constantine's implications and methods, he knows that this is neither the time nor the place for sharing what he's learned.

The words he cannot speak harden into a stone at the back of his throat. Were he to let it fall, the ripples it would send through Laplace would be impossible to calm.

Enigma: I'm simply learning to consider the consequences before I act.

Enigma: Some of the Foundation's committee members have gotten swept up in the prospect of an impending arcane war. If this goes on ...

Enigma: Laplace mustn't become a pawn in their war games, or a bargaining chip for their faction disputes.

Enigma: In short, we need to submit our *Pre-Storm Protocol* as soon as possible.

Enigma: Which means we need to figure out what the core of the toybox really is—no. Whatever it is, we need to crack it open as soon as possible. Alright?

Enigma: If we hurry, we still have a chance to convince the talking heads at the Foundation to leave us be.

Each researcher wears a different expression.

Medicine Pocket: Ha, Enigma, are you actually begging right now? Quick—has the "Storm" stopped? Has hell frozen over?

Enigma: Whatever. Just give me an answer.

The ferrofluid swirls violently in the tank. Then slowly, it settles.

Ulrich: Alright.

Ulrich: It seems there'll be no solving our differences in the short term.

Ulrich: So, I have a proposal: we submit two reports and let the reviewers decide.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Fine.

Beach, Toybox

In the toybox once again, Enigma's exploration has taken him to a beach.

Waves roll in, foaming at the shore. He looks down at the swirling water.

Enigma: From a visual estimate, the "Perfect Language" covers everything in a five-kilometer radius, with the tower as its center.

Enigma: On the beach outside this five-kilometer area, the environment continues to exhibit signs of "language disorder," a new type of Storm Syndrome.

Enigma: It deconstructs words into phonemes, the building blocks of sound, and uses them as the building blocks of matter. A handful of seawater contains ...

Enigma: One, two, three, four ... Roughly twenty phonemes.

Enigma: Though, clearly, the phonemes themselves don't carry any meaning, they do leave room to construct one.

The waves whirl, causing phonemes to clash and ring against one another.

Enigma: The "waves" create a chiming sound. Like bells.

Enigma: This "seawater" holds enough phonemes such that they may organize into morphemes, the smallest units of meaning.

Enigma: Hm. Monkeys may have an easier time putting Shakespeare together here than writing it on typewriters.

A jelly-thick sea breeze brushes Enigma's cheek and carries his wry muttering to the waves' crests.

Then the waves break against the shore again, and the wind shifts.

Enigma: It seems the wind strips even the quietest utterances into the smallest units of sound.

He casts his hearing like a net, carefully sifting out bare phonemes and weaving them back into meaning.

Enigma: Perhaps these symptoms can be understood as a language microscope. Or maybe a scalpel.

Enigma: The environment dissolves and dissects every spoken word, leaving only its phonetic fragments behind.

Enigma: To use language is to quickly combine these pieces into specific sequences to create a meaningful utterance. Thus, one could view this entire environment as a "simulation of language use."

Enigma: Hmm ... Bilabial plosive, diphthong, mid central vowel, nasal. The phonemes of "poem."

Enigma: Hah. I see, it's encryption and decryption. Hardly foreign territory for me.

Enigma:

Enigma crouches down, pulls a small glass vial from his pocket, and fills it to the two-thirds mark with "seawater."

He seals the vial and shakes it. The liquid inside is crystal-clear.

Enigma: It still appears like normal seawater in this container. Let's see if X has any suitable equipment to analyze its composition when I get back.

Enigma: I wonder ... If I bring this vial of "seawater" to the tower, will its "composition" change?

Piece I: @¥%##— (Help!)

The net catches a few strange symbols.

Not far off, several toybox "locals" rush from the reef in a panic.

Enigma: ...?

Puzzled, Enigma watches as they come running straight toward him, crying all the way.

Piece I: *%¥—Critter!!

As they draw closer, the phonemes reassemble into words.

Enigma: This language deconstruction phenomenon seems to have a limited range. Just now the limit was around two meters.

He quickly jots the new finding on the back of his hand, but the locals' shouting robs him of any chance to ponder it further.

Piece I: Please help us!

Piece I: Just cross that reef, walk due west, and you'll find it on the shore!

Enigma: ...

The clamoring callers surround him. No matter which way he steps, they swarm back in an instant.

He tries to convince himself they're nothing but cold data. Not real people. Not worth his time.

Enigma: Critter attacks are common in the toybox. Go find the fellow with the glass tank for a head.

Enigma: I need to get to that tower.

Piece I: Please, please help us! You're the only one here who can!

Piece II: You'll find a way, won't you?

The pieces refuse to take no for an answer. Their reality has made the choice for them—keep pushing.

Enigma glances down at his timer. Ten hours in the toybox already.

Enigma: If I waste time on things like this, I won't make any progress on the tower's function before the simulated "Storm" hits.

Enigma: I need to finish the *Pre-Storm Protocol* before Ulrich does.

Piece III: If we wait any longer, our friend will get hurt!

Piece I: Please help us!

Enigma: ...

Enigma: All the damn pleading—what is this, a time loop?!

When needs collide, the result is either a standoff or a concession, and lately, Enigma has been favoring the latter.

There's not a trace of simulation in the panic on their faces. Not even Laplace's most advanced equipment could reproduce terror so faithfully.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Lead the way.

They cheer and quickly clear a path toward the reef.

On the other side, the "emergency" comes into view: a pack of Critters closing in.

Critter: [Critter-Speech] (Just you wait!)

It doesn't take much before the Critters flee shrieking.

"Hofmann": Even without understanding their language, and with parts of it reduced to incomprehensible noise, their movements convey their fury just fine.

"Hofmann":

"Hofmann":

"Hofmann":

"Hofmann":

"Hofmann": Thank you for lending us a hand.

Enigma: You again.

As he approaches the "trapped survivor," Enigma's eyes fall on a figure before him.

"Hofmann": A simulation of someone he knew better than anyone, built from Greta Hofmann's memory data.

"Hofmann": Hmm?

Enigma: I should've known. This is the only way to the tower.

"Hofmann":

He mutters under his breath and takes a step forward.

It's a waste of time. None of this is real—just an absurd coincidence generated by the toybox's logic.

Enigma: I saw you on my previous expeditions.

"Hofmann": Oh, you're from the outside. This world is constantly resetting, so I'm afraid I cannot recall our previous encounters.

But—

Enigma: The last time I saw you, you were also on your way to explore the depths of the toybox.

Enigma: Is that the case this time as well?

Enigma: I built a tower there, in the depths. But nothing has changed.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: I'm no closer to finding out how to stop the "Storm" in here.

Enigma: Listen to me. This is all a simulation, designed to help us find a solution to the "Storm." No matter what you do, everything will eventually reset to its original state. Nothing will change.

Enigma: You don't have to waste your time like this. You've already made this journey before, and it is difficult and meaningless.

"Hofmann" studies Enigma calmly. He's standing right in front of her, blocking the road ahead.

"Hofmann": I appreciate your concern. It appears this isn't the first time you've observed our actions.

"Hofmann": And I'm glad I was able to help you come to your conclusions.

"Hofmann": However, everything you've said pertains to your business as an outsider. From your point of view, perhaps your claims are correct.

"Hofmann": But I'll only know if your advice is meaningful to me once I get there myself, when I see that tower with my own eyes.

"Hofmann": In any case, I won't be the last to visit it. Perhaps whatever I leave behind will help those who come after.

"Hofmann": Like I've helped you.

Enigma: ...

"Hofmann": Besides, if you've already concluded that this is meaningless, why did you return?

Leaving the question to hang in the air, "Hofmann" brushes past Enigma and follows the road behind him.

Enigma doesn't move. The timer ticks on, converting precious time into numbers.

A moment later, he sets off down the same road.

All Is but a Riddle

CH36101-06

Hofmann Family Home

???: I'm heading out.

???: You can heat up the leftovers in the fridge for lunch. Did you hear that, Adler?

Adler: What's the appeal of the mountaineering club, anyway?

Adler: At this point, even the neighbors are saying, "Looking for Greta? She's probably gone mountain climbing."

Greta: Or rowing.

The young woman at the door has already laced up her shoes. She stamps her feet on the mat.

She shoulders her hiking pack and glances back at her brother as she rises.

Greta: Would you like to come?

Greta: Last time you joined me on the Karwendel climb, before we'd even made it back, you said you'd never participate in any weekend sports events ever again.

Greta: Chess, swimming, or doing those math problems you love—they're all worthy pastimes. There's no need to follow me.

Adler: I only came here to get a glass of water!

Greta: Haha, sure. By the way, I need your help with something.

Greta tosses him a set of keys.

He catches them, his eyes never leaving the crossword in his newspaper.

Greta: What are you poring over now? Planning to lock up Papa's cigarette cabinet behind a code again?

Adler: That was just a Vigenère cipher. A beginner's puzzle.

Greta: Mhm. Anyway, if you have the time, could you mow the lawn in the back garden? It would make Mama and Papa happy.

Greta: And you know, I've never asked—what's got you so dead-set on "Laplace"?

Greta: There are plenty of outstanding research facilities to choose from. Why them?

Adler: Because I believe we share the same ideals.

Greta: Hmm?

Greta: The seriousness in his tone makes her pause. Her hand lingers over the doorknob.

Adler: There must be a theory that unifies everything in the universe.

Adler: Because every puzzle has a solution.

Adler: The world is like a crossword. If you follow the clues, you'll arrive at an answer. The only answer. An established theory.

Adler: It's simple. Clear. Rational.

Adler: Codes simply rearrange symbols according to a set of rules. Identify these rules, and you can decipher it. If we don't have an answer, it doesn't mean it doesn't exist, but rather that we haven't discovered it yet.

Adler: I've attended lectures at Laplace. Their researchers firmly believe they can discover the truth. It's utter conceit.

Adler: But that's the way it should be.

Greta nods and opens the door with a smile.

Greta: I see. Don't worry. I'm sure you'll receive an invitation from them soon enough.

Greta: I've asked around. They all said age is no matter, nor whether or not you're an arcanist.

Greta: Laplace opens its doors to geniuses. That's the only requirement.

Greta: Won't be any trouble for you, dear brother.

Enigma: ...

He crouches and sets the flowers down before the headstone.

They join other bouquets. White chrysanthemums now spill over the edge of the stone and onto the grass.

Enigma: Many people remember you.

Enigma: Even Musae III's toybox has a chunk of data still diligently simulating your stubbornness. Heh.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: But I'm sure you don't want to hear me prattle on about the past.

Whether to convince himself or to push something away, Enigma searches his cluttered thoughts for something else to say.

Enigma: The tower in the toybox, the Tower of Babel we used to solve the "language disorder"—it isn't the final solution.

Enigma: Yes, people are able to use verbal communication to understand each other again. Unprecedented, I know.

Enigma: But this has come at a cost. The pieces' cognitive processes have all unified under the same model.

Enigma: Unanimous agreement, unanimous objection—can this even be considered communication?

He's been staring at the engraved letters for so long that they've started to look strange. It's like this is all some sort of dream.

Enigma: Ulrich and I each set off on our own expeditions. But in the end, we both decided to destroy the tower and take its core.

Enigma: So, now we have a new problem to solve—the core has a combination lock.

Enigma: And I can't make heads or tails of it.

The headstone offers only silence. Though, that doesn't stop Enigma from working out what Greta's response may have been.

Enigma: Ha, I know. You wouldn't understand.

Enigma: This is supposed to be my specialty. Finding clues, cracking codes—all it takes for me is time.

Enigma: But my mind's gone rusty. Even my own thoughts have become unreliable.

Enigma: I haven't done any research of my own in a long time. Oh, no, just pointless meetings and endless paperwork.

Enigma: Trivial, inconsequential matters have absorbed my every waking moment, grinding the old gears in my head to a halt. I can almost hear them creaking when I try to get them turning again.

Enigma: Perhaps, I've lost the talent I once had.

He nods with a bitter smile.

Enigma: Hah, maybe one day soon, I'll be using one of X's inventions. Even his simplest robots couldn't do any worse than me.

The white chrysanthemums whisper in the drifting wind, and as he falls silent, the world's sounds close in around him.

Marcus: Oh! Mr. Enigma.

Marcus: You're here too.

He turns toward the voice. Greta's mentee stands behind him, arms full of documents and flowers.

Enigma: I have a meeting with the Foundation. This was on the way.

Enigma: You're here to see her again.

Marcus: Yes, I've brought some new manuscripts for her to see.

Marcus: These manuscripts ... I'm going to submit them to the *Daydream Post*, but I'm not sure whether I'll be rejected again.

Marcus: I used a different recording technique this time, based on the feedback Madam Hofmann gave me once.

Marcus: So I wanted to show them to her before I got an answer from the magazine.

Marcus: I hope she can see that I've finally figured out what to do with my limitless "reading."

Marcus: Instead of focusing on how much I can "read," I've decided to focus on the specific truths I can glean from them to record the story of the "Storm."

Enigma steps aside. Marcus lays the flowers on top of the documents and sets them both before the headstone.

Marcus: Without betraying my own principles or Madam Hofmann's teachings, I've managed to find a recording technique that can realize my dream.

Marcus: Of course, it's definitely lacking in a lot of ways.

Marcus manages to say what she means, though not without stumbling over herself.

She doesn't know Enigma well. Greta was the lone thread that connected them.

Marcus: Actually, Mr. Enigma, I never thought you'd come here. Oh, I-I don't mean that as a criticism! I only mean, I understand how you were feeling.

Marcus: But I suppose, now you're here, you've found an answer to that question?

Marcus chooses her words with care.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Not yet.

Enigma: But staying like this isn't going to help me think, either.

Marcus: Mm. Well, "reading" takes time. And so does seeking proof.

Enigma: Perhaps. You probably have a lot to say to her. I'll get out of your way.

Enigma reaches into his pocket and feels the cold metal tube in his palm.

He rummages in the other.

Marcus: What's wrong, Mr. Enigma?

Enigma: Nothing. Here.

Marcus opens her hands. Enigma drops something into them and turns to leave.

She looks down. She knows these candies well. Similar ones could always be found in her mentor's pockets.

The sharp, cold scent makes her blink.

Marcus: Oh, mints.

Hallway, Foundation

Their tense, fruitless meeting finally ends. Enigma stands in the busy hall, adrift.

Staff members rush past without noticing him, arms full of files, each load heavier than the last.

Enigma: Ha, talk about using a sledgehammer to crack a nut.

Enigma: What a meaningless waste of resources.

beep—beep—

The communicator rings just in time, cutting off his lingering contempt for the meeting he'd suffered through just half an hour ago.

Pointer: Adler. If you aren't dealing with anything urgent, please return to Laplace as soon as possible.

Enigma: What happened?

Pointer: We've made some new discoveries regarding the tower's core.

Pointer: It changes when observed. We need to come up with a new plan.

Flowing Memories

CH36101-07

Pointer: As you can see, this is the toybox's core.

The core is contained within a metallic frame. At its center, something between a cloud of fog and a jellyfish envelops matter and symbols too strange to name.

Pointer: After running it through some preliminary tests, we discovered its inner contents don't match up with any known arcane material.

Pointer: Our next step would be to record and analyze its center.

Pointer: But there's a problem. The matter and symbols floating in the core seem to change their state every time we observe it.

Without warning, the interior shifts again. Two forms slowly emerge from the "fog."

Enigma: Are those gears?

X: Hmm. I think it looks more like the black and white grid of a crossword puzzle.

X: Adler, your observation right now—the observation of a cryptographer with very distinct interests and inclinations ...

X: Has become a new influencing factor on the core.

Enigma: I understand. Under these circumstances, analyzing its contents is pointless.

Ulrich: Precisely. But the problems don't stop there.

Ulrich gestures toward the toybox on the table.

Ulrich: Within the three-hour period after the core's removal, the environment in the toybox descended into chaos. Understandably so.

Ulrich: The core has an "unmeasurable" quality; it stood to reason that the same quality extended to the toybox.

Pointer: Hissabeth and I entered the box to verify this theory.

Pointer: With its stabilizing core gone, the environment in the toybox has also become affected by its observers. In fact, we found the level of chaos is positively correlated to the number of observers.

Enigma: Observer effect, changing environment ...

Pointer: Familiar, isn't it? Our current situation seems to share many qualities with Artificial Somnambulism.

Pointer: Hissabeth has gone to get reinforcements. Hm, right on time.

Just as Pointer had estimated, Hissabeth leads Mesmer Jr. into the meeting room.

Hissabeth: Go on, time's precious!

Hissabeth steps back. Mesmer Jr. approaches the toybox.

She leans over, peering down at the small, almost real "world" inside.

A textbook "zoo hypothesis."

Mesmer Jr.: I'm sorry, but this isn't the same as Artificial Somnambulism.

After a long pause, she delivers her verdict.

Mesmer Jr.: I don't come to this conclusion arbitrarily. I've been paying attention to your experiments on this toybox.

Mesmer Jr.: Look.

Mesmer Jr.: In your toybox, there's still a vending machine at the entrance to the Laplace laboratories.

Hissabeth: It's true! But out here, that vending machine was removed two days ago.

Mesmer Jr.: Artificial Somnambulism creates images based on subconscious memory. It's blurry and malleable. Even with our guidance, memories can still lie to you.

Mesmer Jr.: That's why we use it primarily for psychotherapy, not simulations for experiments.

Mesmer Jr.: It's likely this toybox is operating on a set formula based on the environmental conditions that were initially loaded, making it unable to generate things not included in its original data set.

Mesmer Jr.: Although your observations have turned into a chaotic mess for the time being, it has no inherent ability to change to reflect the real world.

Mesmer Jr.: That is to say, the data in the toybox is from a static point in the past. If you don't update it, the vending machine will stay.

Mesmer Jr.: It's this lag in data that gives it stability.

Mesmer Jr.: That's the best I can offer.

Hissabeth: No, your conclusion was very valuable. So it's clear. If we want to progress, there's only one way left.

Hissabeth: Return the core to the tower and let the toybox restabilize. Then reset it to stop this entropy and return it to its original state.

Enigma: You mean, we regenerate the outer layer of the core to create a combination lock that can easily be analyzed?

Pointer: Correct. Considering the chaos in the toybox, this mission should fall to you and Ulrich.

Pointer: You two are the most familiar with its environment.

Enigma & Ulrich: ...

Field, Toybox

The all too familiar field of grass appears once more.

Enigma: Why is our starting point always set here?

Ulrich: It seems the toybox is more stable than we expected.

Ulrich: The topography hasn't changed at all, although we have lost line of sight to the tower.

Ulrich looks to the horizon. The tower's spire, once faintly visible, is now swallowed by heavy clouds.

Hissabeth: Don't worry, we've already located the tower.

Through the device, Hissabeth's slightly distorted voice brings them their second piece of good news.

Hissabeth: Although there have been some slight changes, it still remains northeast of where you are.

Hissabeth: Just go ahead. We'll sync with your current position and route.

X: Oh, but can we assume that syncing our data out here won't trigger the observer effect?

Enigma: Let's go.

Confirming that the core is safe inside the container, he shoulders the weight.

Enigma: Please record the time intervals between the toybox's environmental changes.

X: Data's already been synced.

The two researchers wordlessly move northeast.

It seems they have both tacitly chosen silence as their safest option.

For a while, the communicator is the only thing making any sound.

Pointer: Enigma, Ulrich, the data is starting to fluctuate.

Pointer: The observer effect will most likely begin manifesting soon. Prepare yourselves.

They halt. A bubble-like barrier drifts across the plain.

Hissabeth: Oh! This is like a development on the Rorschach test.

Hissabeth: I can hardly wait to see what scenes might appear.

Enigma: How did we end up here?

In the blink of an eye, the plain is gone, and they find themselves at the edge of a lake.

X: Environmental changes took 15 minutes this time. No change in the direction of the tower. Sure looks like a nice fishing spot you've ended up in.

Enigma: Ah. As if we didn't have enough problems, a lake?

Enigma: What, do we have to row a boat now?!

Ulrich: I have no particular fondness for natural environments. I think this one's on you, Adler.

Enigma: Good to see you've finally grasped the most important skill of social interaction—shifting blame.

Enigma: The last time I visited a lake was before I joined Laplace.

Enigma: Admit it, Ulrich! You're curious about them!

Ulrich & Enigma: What happened?!

Their argument is cut short. Like a television switched off, they are plunged into complete darkness.

Pointer: The data's becoming more volatile. The toybox is losing control.

Ulrich: At least the communicator's still working.

Enigma feels around inside his backpack and pulls out the core.

It has warped violently inside its frame, looking nothing like it did before.

Enigma: Which direction is the tower?

Pointer: It's moved. Current position, unclear.

Enigma: There's no easy way ahead for now, so we'll make a temporary stop here. Check the position again after the next cycle of environmental changes.

Ulrich: Wait, Adler.

The darkness has sharpened their hearing. There's a rustling closing in from all sides.

Enigma: Looks like we'll have to deal with this first.

X: You two alright? We've got the data. The tower's new location—it's extremely close to your position!

X: Wait, that's not right. It's ON your position.

The "projector" fast-forwards again, tossing them into the next frame.

Enigma: Yes, we're under the tower.

Tower, Toybox

Enigma: That certainly saved us some effort.

Ulrich: Hmm. If the toybox's environment is affected by its observers' thoughts, then did we arrive here so quickly because our goals completely aligned with one another?

Hissabeth: How about that! A wish-granter and psychoanalysis machine all wrapped into one!

Hissabeth: This would work wonders for my survey on arcane skills!

Enigma: Right, let's get the core into the tower and prepare our next steps.

Just as they reach for the tower door, a shrill cry splits the air.

A raven swoops down from nowhere, snatching the container in its beak and flying into the distance.

Ulrich: Ludwig?! Why is he still here?!

Enigma: Damn it! X, can you follow Ludwig's trail?

Enigma: He's made off with the core!

X: Not a problem. We've got his arcane fluctuations on record! Just hold for a moment.

The communicator hisses with static.

X: A few seconds later, the answer comes through.

X: The tracking data's been interrupted. We lost him after about 50 meters of flight.

X: Mr. Ludwig has left. Or, more specifically, disappeared.

X: Huh. This is residual da ... System error?

X: It'd be best if you ... interrupt ... evacuate as quickly as possible ...

Enigma ignores his pleas, which are now reduced to static. Jaw clenched, he pushes hard against the tower door.

It doesn't budge.

Enigma: ...

Pointer: ... Already ... forced restart ...

Enigma: Hmm?

A metal object lies on the ground in a spot he hadn't noticed before.

Enigma: Greta's badge? She really came all the way here?

He reaches for it without thinking.

Ulrich: Researcher Adler!

Enigma: What?

Ulrich: They've issued the force quit alert! No matter what you see, don't approach it. We have to avoid interfering with the data.

Enigma: But—

Ulrich grabs Enigma by the collar, yanking him off balance.

The mystery of the badge goes unsolved. Their bodies begin to disintegrate into pixels.

Enigma: ...!

Finally, he is pulled from the space. The tower collapses into a cone of light and disappears.

Night Climber

CH36101-08

Adler: Going mountain climbing again?

Adler: Where are you heading this time? Watzmann, Nebelhorn?

Greta: Spain, actually. To the tallest peak in the Pyrenees—Aneto.

Adler: You just finished a field mission. Shouldn't you take more than a day to recover?

Greta: I was only helping them establish an organizational system for their arcanist database in Morocco. And I got plenty of sleep on the plane.

Greta: What about you? Another late night of research, by the looks of it?

Greta: I've heard the people at Laplace are night owls too. You should fit right in with their schedule.

The all-nighter has left Adler looking a little worn, but his eyes are as bright as ever.

Adler: A genius's best thoughts always come at night—an overly poetic sentiment, to be sure, but I see it as a rational conclusion based on experience.

Greta shrugs. She has no intention of nagging him about it the way their parents do.

Greta: Remember—

Adler: I know, mow the lawn.

Adler: ...

Noticing the silence, Greta slows her hand on the door again.

Greta: You look like you still have something to say.

Adler: This month it is setting up an arcanist registry. Last month it was mediating an arcanist dispute, cleaning up after the Foundation's mess.

Adler: I don't think we need more examples. Greta, you're working like Mama sweeping the damn dust behind the door.

Adler: She sweeps and sweeps. Day after day. Year after year. To abate a problem that could be solved by simply closing the window.

Greta: I know you aren't happy with always having to pick up after her in secret, but you shouldn't let Mama know that.

Greta: But, tell me, dear brother, do you think we should close the window forever?

Adler: No, what I meant was ...

Greta waves her hand.

Greta: I never did properly tell you why I joined the Foundation.

Greta: You're right, field investigator work is as you say. While there are complicated procedures to follow, the actual situations are so simple, it hardly takes a genius to figure them out.

Greta: Most of the difficulty comes from dealing with officials. It's entirely up to them whether they drop the red tape and empty rhetoric or raise their walls higher.

Greta: And from a utilitarian standpoint, it's not a rational choice. After all, the promotion prospects are very limited.

Adler: Then why do you insist on doing it?

The stubborn confusion in his voice means this won't be a brief chat.

She glances at the clock on the wall, hesitates, then shifts the weight of her backpack.

Greta: Adler, have you heard of Mount Godwin-Austen? They call it K2.

Adler: The second highest mountain. After Mount Everest.

Greta: That's right. I like the name, K2. Just a letter and a number. It's direct, bare, concise—unembellished. It perfectly captures the image of a "brutal peak."

Greta: That mountain has a higher death rate among climbers than that of the world's highest peak. Once you choose to climb it, you've already put your life in the harsh hands of nature.

Greta: Even among mountaineering clubs, amidst the praise for your determination, I trust the majority of people would still exclaim, "Do you have a death wish?"

Adler: I don't follow.

Greta: The view from the peak of K2—it's different from yours, from the University of Göttingen, or from any other place in the world.

Greta: That's what those people with "a death wish" are trying to obtain.

Greta: Of course, most Foundation field investigators don't face such extreme conditions.

Adler: ...

Greta: I don't understand arcanum. I don't understand the arcanists it creates, either.

Greta: But these things are deeply rooted in our world.

Greta: The Foundation is a great fulcrum, a window, a place to observe, and to participate.

Greta: Even if I wanted to, there's no avoiding dealing with all kinds of arcanists and arcanum.

Greta: They hide, tucked away among the many interwoven branches of bureaucracy. This is a view gained only by joining the Foundation.

Greta: Each arcanist becomes a new case study. Because no matter how bizarre the phenomenon, once it is systematically documented and analyzed, it always falls into a chain of logic.

Greta: Adler, why are you looking for a unified theory?

Adler: To make the world concise, summarizable. It must be knowable and reliable to be suitable for life.

Greta: Do you think society can also have such a theory?

Greta: Something that can integrate all this disordered, chaotic fragmentation and allow arcanists and arcanum to find a place among rationality?

Greta: I believe that's what I'm doing now. I see these endless missions as brute-force exhaustive research, like foolishly trying to count every grain of sand on a beach.

Greta: Once complete, it will give a full view of both humans and arcanists, founded in rationality and worthy of trust.

Greta: Heh, you could call it "Hofmann Idealism." It certainly seems to be in both our blood, dear brother.

Adler: Alright, isn't it quite time you left?!

Greta pays no mind to her brother's embarrassed huff. Something else has occurred to her.

Greta: I heard Laplace is experimenting on arcane skill fusion these days. They plan to distribute equipment infused with the power of incantations to us investigators.

Adler: I'm not going to put my faith in some inexplicable "magic" weapon.

Greta: Mm, I expected you'd say as much.

Greta: Then, this might be more your speed. It's a Luger pistol. A regular firearm, able to be disassembled and reassembled as you see fit.

Adler: A pistol?

Greta: I also have one—it's a Foundation-issued pistol for field investigations. I'd say I already have a solid eye for it.

Adler: Greta, what kinds of missions are you going on that require guns?

Greta: While extreme circumstances are rare, they're bound to happen eventually. In those cases, it doesn't hurt to have a gun. That goes for both of us.

She settles her pack on her shoulders. The half-open door swings wide, and the morning sunlight spills over her. She looks ready to dissolve into it.

Greta: I'm heading out now.

Enigma: Greta, wait!

Greta: Time waits for no one, dear brother. I have to go eventually.

Greta: For every mountain in the world, there will always be someone who seeks to climb it.

Adler: ...!

Adler: Wait, I also—

Adler: Greta—!

Enigma: Greta! Greta!

He pounds his fist against the door. It doesn't move.

A door he knows well. A door he has always wanted to open.

A door he had once opened. A door that opens only for geniuses.

Pointer: Adler, Mr. Adler!

Enigma: ...

He snaps back to reality.

The stares of his colleagues in the Laplace meeting room bore into him.

Ulrich: You've been out of sorts during our recent meetings, Adler. You should get more sleep.

Ulrich: Sleep is a vital function for humans; it—

Enigma: Thank you for your considerable insights into human nature. But that's quite enough.

Enigma: Now to our current situation. We need to figure out our next steps.

The conversation resumes, and the geniuses leave behind the trivial matter of sleep.

Enigma: Ludwig's reappearance has introduced a serious problem.

Enigma: The core is no longer in our hands. Our crossword puzzle has been torn to shreds, and we have no leads to speak of.

Enigma: Even the most skilled cryptographer can't reverse-engineer a key out of thin air.

Medicine Pocket: Seems like an easy fix to me. I say we take apart the toybox.

Medicine Pocket: Ludwig and the core are both in there, right?

Medicine Pocket: So take it apart! Let all its elements reset to their original states individually. Then, it'll be a breeze to analyze.

Ulrich: That's too reckless, Researcher Medicine Pocket! Dismantling the toybox might cause significant data loss.

Ulrich: Or possibly even destroy the toybox itself, then we'll be without any research subject at all!

Medicine Pocket: Well, sitting here overthinking everything isn't gonna produce any results either.

Enigma: Just reset it. We can continue with our original plan.

Enigma cuts in, stopping the argument before it starts.

Pointer: The toybox remains unstable. If we reset it in its current condition, there's no telling whether we'll return everything to its original state or just cause even more chaos.

Hissabeth: Ludwig's signal is still near the tower. We'd better come to a decision before he leaves.

Enigma: No more hesitating. There's no use in waiting.

Enigma: Plus, since the data is restored after each reset of the toybox, we can start by assuming that the mishap with Ludwig has been fixed.

Enigma: We start with a hypothesis, then we test it.

Pending Report

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Preliminary Investigation Report on the Toybox

After the ninth "Storm," Musae III provided the toybox as a tool for simulation experiments to help develop a Pre-Storm Emergency Protocol that meets LSCC standards while adhering to humanitarian principles.

Note: Existing solutions all failed to meet LSCC standards. Based on the scientific principles of "objective investigation, rational skepticism, pluralistic doubt, and equal debate," response plans for the "Storm" should also be tested in practice. Thus, this is not a useless effort or an excuse to play board games at work.

This project, led by Researcher Ulrich and supervised by Researcher Adler, launched after the ninth "Storm" and has been gradually refined. During this period, a technical fault in the box caused a large-scale "language disorder" phenomenon, which stabilized after Researcher Adler's intervention, preventing major losses.

During the "Free Breeze" incident, Researcher Ulrich used preliminary toybox research results —"Artificial Storm" technology—to test the "Regulus" record, achieving significant results. Afterward, due to busy schedules, development of the Pre-Storm Emergency Protocol was temporarily put on hold.

After the tenth "Storm," new anomalies began appearing within the toybox. Researchers Ulrich and Adler disagreed on how to handle the toybox, each submitting separate research reports. These reports are currently being compared and evaluated; specific details are expected in future publications.

The Looping Pangram

CH36101-09

Enigma: After this reset, we need to limit the changes inside the toybox as much as possible.

Enigma: That is to say, the fewer the people who enter the toybox, the better.

Enigma: It's best we only send one person.

Medicine Pocket: I'll do you one better: don't send anyone in and blow it to kingdom come!

Ulrich: Researcher Medicine Pocket.

Medicine Pocket rolls their eyes and keeps talking, unfazed by the warning in Ulrich's tone.

Medicine Pocket: Great, a brand new toybox, and a brand new chance to fail! Consistently reproducing failed results follows the scientific method, too, right?

Medicine Pocket: Seriously. None of us even knows what's in there, and you're saying we should send a single person in alone?

Medicine Pocket: You're totally fine with that, huh? Leaving all those insane pieces and that psycho raven for some unlucky bastard to deal with?

X: This doesn't happen often, but I have to say I agree with Medicine Pocket. Whoever decides to enter will be risking their own safety.

Medicine Pocket rolls their eyes again. X and Ulrich have clearly missed the point.

Medicine Pocket: Ugh. What I was saying is that we shouldn't be wasting our brainpower on this thing.

Ulrich: We also need to consider the pieces. They may just be data to us, but to them, this is their entire world. We must avoid destroying it if we can.

Medicine Pocket: Oh, my dear Ulrich, I'm moved to pieces! If only the real "Storm" shared your glowing sense of humanitarianism.

Hissabeth: Pardon, can I interrupt for a second?

Hissabeth knocks on the table.

Hissabeth: I have good news. I've tested the communicator's durability.

Hissabeth: Although the tower's effect grows stronger the closer you get, the unlucky person entering the box will be able to receive outside help up until they enter the tower. If we aren't giving up on that plan, that is.

Medicine Pocket: That's great, but assigning a hundred people to wash test tubes in a lab isn't gonna make the research go any faster.

Medicine Pocket: That's all that communicator's gonna give. A bunch of test tube washers.

Hissabeth: Don't say that. If you gave me ten research assistants who understood the Lane-Emden equation, I'd be pleased no matter what.

For once, Enigma listens. He waits until Hissabeth is done before he speaks.

Enigma: What I meant is that I will go.

Ulrich: You're a human, Adler. And at the end of the day, that toybox runs on arcanum.

Enigma: Thank you for the reminder, Bottlebrain.

Enigma's tone is polite, but his expression is grim.

Enigma: I'm certain you will all provide more help than test tube washing, like capturing arcane fluctuations and relaying the data through the communicator.

Enigma: Besides, I'm the cryptographer here.

Enigma: I doubt any one of you has undergone even a fraction of the cryptographic training required to reverse-engineer a key from an as-of-yet unknown cipher.

Hissabeth: Well, I certainly haven't.

Hissabeth: But I believe I understand now. You think Ulrich has a point, too. Humanitarian care, no?

Enigma: Where on earth did you get that impression?

He turns away, but his darkening expression doesn't escape Hissabeth's notice.

Hissabeth: Alright, you're right. You didn't say that.

She shrugs and clears the way for Enigma.

Enigma: ...

A faint dizziness blurs Enigma's vision.

Lake, Toybox

Everything has changed.

Frowning, Enigma pats his wet coat, sending little streams down into the moonlit water below—assuming that is indeed moonlight and water.

Medicine Pocket: Woah, look at that ball of light in the sky! Hah, I'm starting to like this place!

Enigma: I'm afraid that's this toybox's version of the moon.

He pulls himself upright against the knee-high silver lines and wades unsteadily toward the shore.

X: Hey, those fir trees over there look like snowflakes.

Enigma: Why don't you tell me something I don't know?

X: Alright. I just thought some talk on Koch curves might lighten the topic.

Enigma: Can anyone tell me how to mute this thing?

Enigma distances himself from the communicator as another wave of commotion erupts on the other end. A moment later, Ulrich's calm voice comes through.

Ulrich: Understood. Researcher Pointer and I will strictly control the others' input as requested.

Hissabeth: Umm, right, we guarantee we'll only bother you if it's essential.

Enigma: Thank you. I'll contact you if necessary.

He switches off the communicator, yet the surrounding noise persists.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Who's there?

Not far off, a young piece turns around, hands twisted together nervously.

"Marcus": Mr. Enigma?

Enigma: Didn't expect I'd run into you here, "Ms. Marcus."

Enigma: Are you reading?

He points at the thin white cuboid in the piece's hand.

"Marcus": Yes, Mr. Enigma, I-I'm reading a story. The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog.

Enigma: That's the story? Ah, I understand.

"Marcus": Mhmm. It's about legends and people who write history. I haven't finished it yet. The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog.

She smiles shyly. What used to be a book has slowly flattened into a colorless, almost depthless shape.

"Marcus": Is there something I can help you with? Quick.

Enigma: I'm looking for a tower. Do you know where it might be?

"Marcus": It seems—fox—a lot of people are looking for that tower ... It—quick—might be on the other side of the forest.

Enigma: Thank you.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Ms. Marcus. Would you like to come with me?

She looks bewildered. The book finally loses the last of its depth and slides from her arms.

"Marcus": I'm waiting for someone. How—quick—strange. I-I don't seem to remember who I'm waiting for. Brown.

Enigma: Was she also looking for the tower?

"Marcus": The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog.

Enigma: Forget it.

Enigma hesitates, then crouches to pick the book up for her. But it slips through his fingers, like the moon's reflection slipping from cupped hands.

He shakes his head and gives up. It's useless anyway.

Enigma: I should go, Ms. Marcus. Goodbye.

He strides away. The girl's voice follows after him.

"Marcus": Please—brown—be careful! There's a fox, brown in the forest. Lazy dog!

Enigma: Thank you.

Following the piece's direction, Enigma squints into the distance. The white tower's spire rises above a sea of treetops.

Enigma: Hah. How wonderfully eye-catching. What is this, Tantalus's punishment?

Another figure emerges from the shadows of the trees.

Laplace Researcher I: Danger. Closer don't any come!

Laplace Researcher I: Wait, you're ...?!

He knows this researcher. The toybox is pulling from his buried memories.

Enigma: It's me. A tiny, insignificant cryptographer.

Enigma: It's a pity we've never worked together.

The communicator rings again. Whether it's at the worst moment or the best one, he can't decide.

Hissabeth: Adler, how bad is it?

He subconsciously reaches into his pocket. The metal tube is cold against his fingers.

Enigma: Oh, fine. Just a piece who's gone mad.

Enigma looks up at the top of the tower for what feels like the thousandth time. It's faintly glowing.

He raises the communicator.

Enigma: We have a problem.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Even after all this walking, I haven't gotten any closer to the Tower of Babel.

Enigma: If anything, it appears to be growing farther and farther away.

That Familiar Bitterness

CH36101-10

Hissabeth: We're all quite used to the "language disorder" by now, so that isn't much of a problem, and there isn't much need for him to communicate with anyone.

Hissabeth: But what does concern me is that moving tower. A brand new variable ...

Hissabeth: What was it again? There was an expression I heard when I was trying to research Kiperina's and Name Day's arcane skills.

Hissabeth: Oh! That's the one! "People can only borrow language; they cannot reach the reality behind it."

Ulrich: We need to start considering the possibility of evacuating Adler early.

Hissabeth: I doubt he'll agree.

Ulrich: Then prepare to evacuate him by force. If necessary.

Ulrich: From what we've seen so far, the situation is far worse than predicted. Not only has the "language disorder" encompassed the whole toybox, but it's starting to leak out of it, too.

Ulrich gestures to Hissabeth. The silver patterns on his uniform are slowly fading. She examines him carefully and reaches a quick conclusion.

Hissabeth: Oh, you're right. You HAVE been standing closest to the box.

She exchanges a look with Ulrich and picks up the communicator.

Hissabeth: Alright, I'll tell him. Saves the two of you from bickering again.

Hissabeth: Adler, can you hear me?

Enigma: I hope you have some good news.

Hissabeth: Sorry for what I'm about to say, but I'll keep it straight: the toybox's instability is higher than predicted. We advise you to return early.

Hissabeth: If you can't retrieve the core soon, we'll have to use our backup plan—blowing up the box.

Enigma goes quiet for a few seconds.

Enigma: And Bottlebrain agrees with this?

Ulrich: I didn't want this either. But right now, there's no better solution.

Enigma: Ulrich, what are you saying?

Enigma: Ulrich, what are you saying?

Ulrich: The disorder is spreading to Laplace again. Your time in the box is limited.

Ulrich: And according to the *LSCC Safety Management Regulations*, ensuring your safety is the higher priority.

Enigma takes a deep breath, yet doesn't argue.

Enigma: I understand. Give me two hours. If I don't make any progress, I'll return.

Enigma: Then we can blow it up together.

Ulrich: Two hours, Adler. We'll do whatever we can to help.

Ulrich: Researchers X, Medicine Pocket, and Hissabeth are currently dealing with the spread of the disorder. I also need to step away for a moment to deal with it.

Ulrich: Researcher Pointer is monitoring the toybox's situation. If you run into any danger, be sure to request assistance immediately.

Enigma: I will.

He looks up again at the white spire—seemingly within reach, yet forever beyond it.

Enigma: Hmm?

Maybe it's just his imagination, but for a moment, it felt like he was closer to it.

The journey that follows is too quiet, almost dull. The only thing Enigma can do is note the changes in the surrounding scenery.

He keeps his eyes peeled, but no other familiar faces appear.

Until a heated argument, even for Laplace's standards, breaks out ahead.

A researcher and an administrator argue on opposite sides of a desk in a strange, yet somehow familiar, scene.

Enigma: ...?

Research Staff: I am NOT redoing the material reimbursement.

Administrative Staff: Then you can choose not to submit it. But I must remind you that the reimbursement deadline is this Friday.

Enigma feels a familiar irritation itch at him as the argument dredges up his own unpleasant memories.

Research Staff: Picrasma extract has extremely potent side effects.

Administrative Staff: Laplace ought to tear down the building and install turf!

Enigma: Hmm?

The researcher suddenly draws a gun on his colleague. Perhaps he doesn't think of him as one.

Research Staff: <ERROR> Are-are-are-are you done??!! @# You're wasting Laplace resources!

Research Staff:

Bang. The staff member drops to the ground. Enigma isn't sure whether he should step forward and do something.

Research Staff: Liberation for all the Critters in the canteen!

Before he can decide, a pack of Critters pours out from behind the researcher piece and lunges at him.

Enigma: What on ...?!

Stopping them isn't difficult. After so many explorations, Enigma has grown used to it.

The communicator's ring interrupts his mulling over the sudden change.

Ulrich: We're back. This time the disorder's symptoms are visual. Nothing too serious.

Ulrich: It's a shame you can't see us right now—gathered around the toybox with symbols floating around our heads.

Enigma pictures it and can't help but rub his temples.

Ulrich: What's the situation?

Enigma: Nothing much to report. Though, a piece just did something I'm sure we've all wanted to.

Hissabeth: He applied for a massive amount of funds?

Enigma: No, he killed the administrator who asked him to resubmit his invoice, then led a dozen Critters in an attempted uprising.

Hissabeth: Very extreme. Interesting.

Ulrich: Now, now, there's no one here who wants to do anything like that to our colleagues.

Enigma: To each their own. I'd like to confirm something.

Enigma: You just returned this moment, yes? Was anybody thinking about invoices, the canteen, or anything related to Picrasma candy just now?

X: Hey, why all the questions? Mr. Enigma, this isn't exactly the time for a workplace interview.

Enigma: Come on! Stop the chatter and tell me, quickly!

Medicine Pocket: Oh, you mean you think our observations out here are having an impact in there?

Medicine Pocket: Right! The approval you owe me, it's still in the back of my mind! You already got it, right? The bottle of Picrasma—

Enigma: That's the one.

His hypothesis is confirmed.

Enigma: Now, I need you to give me some time.

Enigma: Stay away from the box. Do not observe my movements.

Ulrich: I see. We'll avoid any eye contact with the toybox.

Pointer: Remember, we have forced evacuation measures in place, Adler.

Silence follows.

Enigma holds his breath and watches.

...

...

Enigma: As expected.

The Critters slowly disappear, and the blood-covered researcher shuffles back to the desk—now simply some grids.

Research Staff: Hey, pal. Coming through!

Research Staff: Sorry, need to reorganize all these receipts ASAP. You heard him, didn't you? The deadline's Friday! Don't your projects need reimbursements, too?

Enigma: Thanks for the reminder, but my team is still waiting for funding approval.

Research Staff: Ah. Must be tough. Hang in there!

He pats Enigma on the shoulder, then limps toward the far wall where there should be a lab.

Enigma: Ulrich, I assume you've also come to the same conclusion.

Ulrich: The correlation between the degree of observation and the toybox's abnormalities.

Enigma: Exactly. Put this down in your report: The reason I made you all leave wasn't because I harbored any ill will toward my colleagues.

Enigma: As we all know, every new observer adds a degree of freedom. The higher the degree of freedom, the harder it is to converge at a single point.

Enigma: Someone wants to see a dark room, so they turn on a flashlight.

Enigma: But if ten people in different corners of the room simultaneously turn on their flashlights, between all the beams of light, not one of them can see clearly.

Enigma: This we understood. But what we failed to account for was the light shining through the window—the people outside the room.

Enigma: Not only do those who enter the toybox increase interference, but so too do those who observe from the outside!

The communicator goes silent. Clearly, Ulrich is thinking fast.

Ulrich: An astonishing conclusion, Adler, but it's a line of thought worth testing.

Ulrich: Do you think two hours of basic cryptography training would be enough for one of our colleagues to enter the box and take your place?

Enigma: No need to complicate things.

Enigma: We can cut off communications now.

Ulrich: What did you say?

Enigma: Turn off the flashlight, and the room will return to its original appearance.

Enigma: Every flashlight, including my own.

Ulrich: Let me remind you again: you're not an arcanist. You can't detect the arcane fluctuations in the toybox on your own.

Enigma: Yes I can. Although the effects won't last for long.

He pops open the metal tube in his pocket.

Enigma: I still have faith in science, even in an era where rain falls in reverse. It's reliable by nature: systematic, comprehensive, replicable.

Enigma: As for arcanum, I may as well make the most of it while it's mine to use. Thankfully, its basic applications don't require deep understanding.

Enigma: I'll ensure my own safety.

A rare silence follows from the other end of the communicator. As the candies drop into Enigma's palm, the reply finally comes.

Ulrich: Of course. You're an exceptional researcher and our greatest cryptographer.

Ulrich: You still have thirty minutes, plus the two additional hours we've approved.

Ulrich: Best of luck. See you soon, Adler.

Enigma: See you soon, Ulrich.

He nods and hangs up.

Enigma: ...

He's on his own now. Enigma draws a deep breath and closes his eyes.

Not to observe, but to sense.

An unfinished antidote and a trace of test poison—to keep Manus Vindictae from using it to cause another tragedy.

He's tried it countless times. It should work.

The taste of Picrasma extract creeps up from the back of his tongue. Enigma's one-quarter arcanist blood briefly awakens.

Emotion and reason.

Arcanist and human.

Arcanum and science.

Science carried him to the point where there seemed to be no going forward.

Arcanum has allowed him to touch the faint glimmer of light in the cracks.

In the deepest dark, there's a soft knock on a brick.

Open Sesame · 1/2

CH36101-11

Enigma: ...

Enigma: What an absurd experience.

Enigma: Using my eyes to gauge the distance, what I saw was a far-off tower and the many difficulties to reach it.

Enigma: That, I realize now, was another result of my "observation."

Enigma: Yet the moment I stop trying to logically deduce its location, lo and behold—here it is.

He touches the white wall before him, as if to confirm it's really there.

Enigma: If arcanists truly live in a world of such unpredictability as this, it's little wonder many think they have mental problems.

Enigma: Alright. Since everything's been reset, that thieving raven will likely reappear at the tower with his shiny contraband in tow.

Enigma: The only problem is getting inside.

Where a door should be, there is only a wall.

Enigma tilts his head back and estimates the tower's height, weighing whether it's worth the climb.

Enigma: There aren't enough footholds. And I'm not certain whether that structure up there is in fact a window.

He pauses, then lowers his voice.

Enigma: Open sesame.

The wall doesn't answer, nor does it mock him for trying.

Enigma: Arcanists can't just make up incantations, it seems. I thought as much.

Enigma: Surely I don't have to delve into my imagination.

He closes his eyes, still facing the stubborn wall.

Enigma: Arcane skills. Arcane skills! How on earth do they figure out these things?!

Enigma: I should've asked for a copy of *A Basic Guide to Using Arcanum* before cutting off communications!

Enigma: Never mind. The principles ought to be about the same. Focus your mind and let the intensity of your thoughts bore a hole in the wall.

???: Not hoping to turn your thoughts into a sledgehammer, are you?

Enigma's eyes snap open. The unchanging darkness is gone.

He follows the sound upward. The raven glides down for a smooth landing.

Ludwig: I never expected the ever-logical Adler would have such a wild imagination.

Enigma: Enough wasting time. Hand it over.

Ludwig: You didn't make all that effort making your way here simply to rob me, did you? Hm, seems Laplace hasn't been so busy these days.

Enigma: As you can see, your instincts have interfered with our work.

Enigma: If you enjoy collecting shiny things so much, I'll give you this communicator. Take it, or any other thing you want.

Ludwig: Empirical judgments, overly confident speculations. Yes, that's the way you think.

Ludwig: And why you'll never comprehend the use of arcane skills.

Enigma: That's irrelevant.

Enigma: Has the simulation been upgraded, or are you being affected by corrupted data?

Enigma: The others haven't shared much personal information on "Ludwig." Are you German?

Ludwig: Ludwig just mechanically turns his head and fixes his gaze on him.

Ludwig: I understand what you want exactly.

Ludwig: You've come to this tower many times, seeking to destroy it and this farce of an experiment.

Ludwig: Then, something changed. You became curious—wanted to uncover its secrets. The natural instinct of a researcher.

Ludwig: But you turned far too hasty in your pursuit, even starting to explore matters you could never hope to understand.

A constant stream of words flows from Ludwig's beak.

Enigma: Enough chit-chat. You ...

Ludwig: Du kannst das Arkanum nicht begreifen.

Enigma: Stop!

He finally understands the source of his discomfort.

He has never sensed arcane fluctuations before. Not until now.

Of course, he can't immediately detect the abnormalities quietly building around him.

Ludwig: Darum kannst du diese Tür nicht öffnen.

Enigma grabs the communicator and throws it at the raven, who effortlessly dodges with a flap of his wings.

Ludwig: You're the one interfering with my experiment, Researcher Adler. I need the core to help me unveil the mysteries of language.

Ludwig: In fact, not long ago, I made a rather decent discovery.

Another flap of black wings. Enigma notices data flowing across them.

Their silhouette begins to melt away, giving way to the cold gleam of metal beneath.

Enigma: Was that hypnosis? A curse? Or a prophecy?

Enigma: All that nonsense, and yet nothing has come of it. Most likely needs time to activate.

Enigma checks his timer.

Enigma: There's still half an hour left. Enough time to get you out of my way.

Ludwig: I need the core. It stays here.

Late Warning
小径

Missing Bird Poster

> Name: Ludwig
> Race: Arcanist
> Characteristics: His head resembles that of a raven.
> Arcane Skill: Ludwig can use language to influence people's thoughts. If you hear him use an imperative sentence directed at you, cover your ears immediately. Do not listen to him. You cannot realistically resist its effects unless you can think without using words.
> Time of Disappearance: Officially confirmed missing during personnel checks after the ninth "Storm."
>
> If you find Ludwig, or a raven that might be him, please contact the nearest chief-level personnel.

Open Sesame · 2/2
CH36101-11

The fortress crumbles. The metal dissolves like foam. Ludwig twitches on the ground.

He spreads his wings and struggles into an upright position. Data flashes in his black eyes.

Ludwig: My data. You've utterly destroyed it.

Enigma: We both know the box will reset. And you'll go back to your chattering, Raven.

Ludwig: Ah, yes. The pieces exist in a world that may be reset. One might think their lives are full of opportunity and that everything is recoverable.

Ludwig: But under special conditions, these pieces can also "die."

Enigma: What do you mean?

Ludwig: The core's contents have the ability to interfere with everything around it. It can tear your mind apart, even scramble your data into a jumbled mess.

Ludwig: Opening its protective shell won't bring you the results you're looking for.

Ludwig: Ludwig already paid the price for his curiosity. His experiment failed, and his mind was imprisoned here. It wasn't until a short while ago that he finally departed.

Ludwig: I am merely a segment of leftover data. An attempt to warn other curious minds to stay well away from danger.

Enigma: You mean to say your actions came from good intentions?

Enigma: Care to explain that incantation of yours? It still hasn't taken effect.

Ludwig: It was meant to change your mind—to prevent you from comprehending the arcane presence here. In stopping you from entering the tower, you would be protected from the madness and ruin that awaits.

Ludwig: There's no need for you to go the way of the other pieces who came here, breaking down piece by piece until you eventually vanish into nothing.

His feathers begin to fall. More symbols flicker across his body.

Ludwig: But you needn't worry. It won't be long until my arcane skill ceases to function.

Enigma: I've never had the opportunity to work with Ludwig. But based on your simulation of him, I can guess he's a stubborn, conceited, curious, egotistical fellow.

Ludwig: Oh, not really. Just a raven cursed with knowledge trying his best to protect those who come after.

Enigma: *sigh* A typical Laplace employee.

Ludwig: You're unhappy.

He studies Enigma with eyes that no longer shine.

Enigma: No. I was only thinking that perhaps there should be someone who helps bear the risks and make decisions on behalf of these geniuses.

Enigma: Working alongside colleagues with no understanding of lab safety protocols comes at too great a price. Having a branch director go missing for so long must have certainly affected productivity.

Ludwig catches the anger in his words and the trace of grief beneath it. He tries to move past both.

Ludwig: But you and I have never worked together.

Enigma checks his timer again.

Enigma: We've been colleagues for the last ten minutes.

Ludwig: You're not going to heed my warning, are you? You're still going to remove the core—to satisfy your curiosity.

Enigma: I AM going to take it. Because I want Laplace to remain a place for people like you.

Enigma: Someone has to do something.

Ludwig nods.

Ludwig: What a coincidence. Some of the previous pieces who came here said a similar thing.

Ludwig: Their data was also destroyed. Unless new data is uploaded, they'll never appear in the box again.

Ludwig: I'm not entirely sure what to call it. I hope you'll forgive me for presuming it as "death."

Ludwig: Which, I believe, is precisely what I'm experiencing now.

Ludwig: Farewell, my colleague. I wish you all the best.

Ludwig vanishes into the air, and on the wall behind where he had stood, a door appears.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: Farewell.

Enigma approaches the door.

That Endless Green

CH36101-12

knock

All for nothing.

Enigma: Next time a colleague disappears without a trace, they'd better leave behind more clues first.

Enigma: Not even a crack. This isn't drawn on, is it?

Enigma: No visible locks. No signs of arcane skills, either.

But to whom?

Enigma: Greta's been here. She found a way through. There must be a way.

Laplace Researcher I: Researcher Adler?

Laplace Researcher I: Researcher Adler, how are you? We've all been quite concerned about your condition.

Laplace Researcher I: The results of our investigation into the "Storm" have arrived, and everyone's fighting to form research teams. This might be a bit presumptuous, but we'd like to invite you to join us.

Laplace Researcher II: That's right! You probably don't remember, but during a cryptography lecture at the University of Göttingen, you said, "Every puzzle has a solution," and that if there's no answer, it's just because we haven't figured out the rules yet.

Laplace Researcher II: This is just like that—a crossword puzzle that nobody's ever solved! We'll be entering new territory! The first to research the "Storm"!

Laplace Researcher I: And we'll be the first to find a solution—to figure out the truth!

He stares at the crossword before him, the letters in its squares drowned in ink so thick they're illegible.

Just like the "Storm," covering everything, with no pattern at all.

Enigma: A solution?

Enigma: A "solution" that can be overturned at any time by the appearance of an inexplicable presence?

Enigma: Only a fanatic would find joy in all this. At least they finally have some evidence that gods are real.

Hofmann: I hear they've given you a nickname, dear brother.

Enigma: Hmm.

Hofmann: "Enigma." You must admit your colleagues have quite the sense of humor and taste, if you ask me.

She sets down a stack of files.

Hofmann: You may be helping with some decoding work in here, and somehow turned me into your personal news and paper delivery girl.

Hofmann: But this house isn't a laboratory, nor your dorm, and it's certainly not an emergency shelter.

Hofmann: There is no harm in returning to a normal life.

Enigma: I'm listening.

Hofmann: No, you aren't.

Enigma sighs and sets down the squash ball in his hand.

Enigma: Alright, fine. I'll say what you want me to say: How's the situation outside, Greta?

Enigma: Everyone must be very busy. They've given up on sending smart robots to my door, and they haven't asked me to join their various research teams for quite some time.

Enigma: Has the "Storm" research had any new breakthroughs? Is everyone in high spirits? Busy coming up with great ideas?

She's quiet for a moment, then shakes her head slightly.

Hofmann: Another "Storm" hit. It was sudden. I heard there were researchers gathering data outside. They didn't make it back in time.

Hofmann: The situation at the Foundation isn't much better.

Enigma: ...

He wants to slam his fist on the table. Instead, he just pushes the papers aside, exhausted.

Enigma: Is that so? I see.

There must be a reason. Something that has driven you here, to stand before this door. To demand a response that has never come.

Self-expectations.

Adler: I've attended lectures at Laplace. Their researchers firmly believe they can discover the truth. It's utter conceit.

Adler: But that's the way it should be.

Others' expectations.

Enigma: I'll take up that role and do what you've been nagging me to do. I'll take care of those pesky committees.

Enigma: But just so you know, I'm not doing this for the higher-ups who look down on us—

Enigma: But for the people who look up to us from below!

A wish to change everything.

Enigma: Because I want Laplace to remain a place for people like you.

Enigma: Someone has to do something.

He has never truly looked at this door. Difficulties and obstacles are common in research. Every result is built on countless failures.

For the first time, he takes a few steps back to get a clear look at this old enemy, the one he has been wrestling with for as long as he can remember.

Enigma: I should've done this a long time ago. No.

Enigma: No need to speculate on how the past could have gone. There's an excellent opportunity—right here and now.

The Picrasma extract is wearing off. His heartbeat pounds in his ears as everything he perceives slowly returns to what it was.

Enigma: Everything inside the toybox changes with observation. It faithfully recreates my every thought, perception, and idea.

Maybe it's the side effects of the extract. Maybe it's the absurdity of what he sees, and how unsurprising it all is. A searing pain rises behind his eyes.

Enigma: Hah. Turns out there was no wall around the door after all.

An unknown darkness engulfs him.

He steps forward with ease.

The place where his toybox journey began. The place where it ends.

Field, Toybox

Every journey began at this field. He recognizes the feeling of the grass beneath his boots.

Enigma: Hm. Back where I started?

Enigma: Not bad.

Parting the blades, he makes his way toward the center.

The core rests there in the grass, waiting for the next stubborn seeker to pick it up.

Ludwig: The core can read one's thoughts, and make the toybox manifest whatever one desires most.

Ludwig: I wanted to create a language without limits, a language everyone could understand and use. And so, it rebuilt the Tower of Babel for me.

Ludwig: It is far too powerful. If you take it, you'll be engulfed by it—something I don't want to happen.

Ludwig: But it's clear you've made your decision. I'm powerless to stop you. I can only wish you the best of luck, and hope you stay true to your convictions.

Ludwig: If I had the time, I'd like to have witnessed what it creates for you.

There is endless green in countless places. Maybe it's the mountaintop he once reached. Maybe it's the graveyard he can't bring himself to visit. Maybe it's the open field in front of the Laplace building.

All he wanted was to return to that first field of grass.

Enigma: Alright. Adventure's over.

Enigma bends down and picks up the core.

Enigma: Good. It's created a new code under my observation. A familiar, basic code.

Enigma: And, a hint.

Enigma: "The age of humans has come to an end."

He reads the words under his breath.

This is as close to reality as the simulation gets—replicating appearance, language, and thought. The data does its job, producing the most reasonable result it can.

In the real world, there is a note just like this in his drawer, taken from that pioneer's journal. She found the answer. Even here, in the simulation.

Proof that she will walk this path every time, without exception. A prophecy written in data.

Enigma: Ha. Arcanum.

The Sound of Prejudice

小径

Divide

There was once a divide between the two.
It was life. It was death. It was a bout of rain.
Those who came after questionedthe true nature of the divide.
It was bloodline. It was reason. It was a flash of insight.
A brave soul leaps across and turns to look back at the divide.
He sees a door never meant to be openedand an imaginary wall.

Fellow Travelers

CH36101-13

Enigma: The Vigenère cipher. A multi-layered application of the Caesar cipher.

Enigma: In this scenario, using Kasiski's test to reverse-engineer the key from known ciphertext is the most suitable approach.

Enigma: Usually, the key isn't particularly long. It was most likely repeated to generate this ciphertext.

Enigma: Simply find the repeating character sequences and use the distance between them to infer the key's length ... It must be a multiple.

He hasn't worked on something like this in a long time.

A simple puzzle. Simple enough that he once walked his family through it as a clever little trick.

Enigma: Where did I put that German letter frequency table?

Enigma: First, calculate the index of coincidence; then try each possible key combination in order. Hmm, Laplace's computers must operate at remarkably high speeds.

Enigma: All that remains, then, is to pick out the plaintext with the most meaning.

Enigma: Done.

He picks up the device.

Enigma: And to think, this is the answer generated from my observation.

Enigma: I'd expected it to be something far more mundane. Like "squash" or "answer."

Enigma: Zukunft.

The metal melts into a soft liquid, and the indecipherable symbols fall away.

He has solved it.

And his reward is an unbearable truth.

Enigma: Urgh!

Enigma: This is ...

He can no longer see the arcane glow, yet the burning behind his eyes returns all the same.

His vision blurs. His arms begin to tremble. Everything around him collapses inward, like a crushed cardboard box.

Enigma: These intense arcane fluctuations, I've seen them before.

Enigma: Damn it, first I need to—

The metal returns to its original form. The secret was revealed for only a moment, but that moment was enough.

The lock isn't there to keep knowledge in. It's there to protect those too ignorant to survive it.

Enigma: I must have seen something like this before, I ...

Enigma: I'm ... Yes. It was when they tried to read that incantation aloud—

The first circle.

The miraculous knot.

The thing you will remember till the day you die—

Enigma's fingers fly across the keys, pulling up files from the Laplace database.

Enigma: "... High concentrations of asymmetrical nuclide R were detected in certain locations."

Enigma: "Upon inspection, these concentrations were not correlated with any external factors."

Enigma: "These locations did not follow any particular distribution pattern, nor did they overlap with the results of our geological surveys."

Enigma: "Based on our current research, the arcane fluctuations at these locations are similar to those of an activated Hofmann Knot, both sharing the same tremor frequency ..."

Enigma: "Some posit this as a blessing of sorts, resulting from the worship of a supreme existence. For example, the School of Apeiron's belief in the Boundless One spared them from the effects of the 'Storm' ..."

Enigma: "And Ms. Amundsen's self-described worship of the Mother Spirit is most likely connected to the mutation she underwent ... All of these locations had records of relatively extended periods of deity worship ..."

Enigma: Hahahaha, tsk!

Enigma: "Supreme existence"? "Deity"?

Enigma: If there were a unifying theory to describe the entire universe, even these so-called gods would be scientifically explained!

Puppets manipulated by invisible strings.

Enigma leans forward, head bowed. He stares at the cold metal core in his hands.

Doubt and mockery harden into anger, which then instantly morphs into something stronger.

Curiosity.

Enigma: What a helpful little assistant you are.

In the Suitcase

Lucy: The news you brought back was very interesting, Simone.

Assistant Simone: Madam Z has always maintained a cooperative attitude toward Laplace. It should have come as no surprise to you.

The glowing bar of her "eye" flickers. This is the latest expression Madam Lucy has learned, roughly the equivalent of a human wink.

Data analysis has shown it can lighten the mood and convey warmth, making it particularly well-suited for conversations between friends.

Lucy: I did not expect Laplace would receive such unique research materials.

Lucy: The details contained in the core of that toybox have created a new basis for greater exploration and research into the "Storm." Perfecting the immunity ritual has become a more likely possibility.

Lucy: The report also mentions that researchers Adler and Medicine Pocket collaborated to develop an antidote for Picrasma extract.

Lucy: I did not use the wrong names, correct?

Assistant Simone: Correct. Your data loss has alleviated considerably.

Assistant Simone: Although a significant portion of data still remains irrecoverable with our current abilities, it's only a matter of time until we find a solution, Madam Lucy.

Lucy: Good. Then, I will apply for some even more complex research tasks when the time comes.

She nods seriously.

Lucy: I have finished composing a response to Researcher Adler's letter.

Lucy: First, the antidote is undoubtedly an invention with immense practical value, allowing Picrasma extract to be used to greater effect.

Lucy: However, their testing methods went against regulations. They have violated Articles 51 and 106 of the *Laplace Laboratory Code of Conduct*.

Lucy: While I congratulate Researcher Adler on his official appointment as director, I must also warn him that he will appear on this month's public notice board for these violations.

Assistant Simone: In other words, everyone will see his appointment and his breach of regulations announced side by side.

Assistant Simone: Based on my estimates, this has a 92% chance of occurring. Approaching certainty.

Simone smiles.

Lucy: Hmm. There is something else I do not understand.

Lucy: Does Laplace currently have a large surplus of paper? All this information could have been relayed via communication device.

Assistant Simone: It's generally considered that letters are a more formal form of notice.

Assistant Simone: Any other thoughts on his appointment? Would you like me to monitor Researcher Adler's performance during his first three months as director?

Lucy: There is no need to scrutinize this specific matter, Simone.

Another flicker of her "eye." She runs her fingers over the letter on the desk.

Lucy: I am still functioning. Thus, there are still people who seek answers to the world's unsolved mysteries, and those who work to uncover its unknown principles.

Lucy: We continue to walk the path of progress.

Don't Look Back in Anger

CH36101-14

Z: This is a very thorough report.

Z: And knowing where you stand, it's safe to say Laplace won't be facing many more problems for the time being.

She flips through the files and nods.

Enigma: Our research will continue until we uncover the truth behind the toybox.

Enigma: After we establish the Toybox Research Group, I'll be sure to submit more detailed reports of our results. What you have there is far from our final conclusion on the subject.

Enigma: Or on our collaboration with the Foundation.

Between compromises, this soon-to-be director has learned how to hold his ground.

Z: Anyone who gives a final answer without careful consideration is either a gambler or a cheat.

Z: I'm glad to see your prudence and rationality as a researcher remain as dependable as ever.

Z: Of course, I'm even happier you've finally decided to be more than just a researcher.

Enigma: I'm sorry, but even now, I still don't fully understand your decision.

Enigma: I also have one more condition.

Z: Go ahead.

Enigma: Before my appointment is officially announced, I want to meet with the Timekeeper.

Enigma: The Foundation's stance is not fully representative of the Timekeeper's, is it?

Z: Under the framework of our new bill, the Timekeeper and her team do enjoy a greater degree of autonomy.

An answer that is both ambiguous and clever. Such autonomy still falls within the Foundation's legal framework.

Z: Regardless, this isn't a difficult request to fulfill.

Z: Laplace's research findings have made many major contributions to the Timekeeper's operations. Rebuilding trust during this period of turmoil is essential.

Enigma: You've become quite proficient at all this.

Enigma: Heh, and I'm just finally starting to get used to it.

Z: Maintaining Laplace's independence, meeting with the Timekeeper ... Is there anything else?

Enigma is quiet for a moment.

Enigma: Before the Foundation requests the details of any of Laplace's research, they must inform me what it will be used for.

Enigma: Can you accept this?

Z: ...

Z: The Foundation has never deliberately concealed anything from Laplace. We've always guaranteed your right to know.

Enigma: Yes, but the reasons they provide could easily be half-truths—or arrive late.

Enigma: I don't mean to make your life difficult, but you know better than I the reality of how the Foundation operates.

Enigma: Judging by your reaction, you can't make that promise. I expected as much.

She neither confirms nor denies it.

Enigma: I have no other requests.

All those endless meetings finally prove their worth. The strategic concession—a classic among "expert negotiators."

Not meant to get anything specific, but to make a point.

Z: Very good.

She pauses.

Z: You'll be notified of the official appointment within the week, after which it will be announced to every department. Hopefully, we won't run into any trouble.

She glances around the room.

Z: You have a lot of paperwork ahead of you.

Z: Why not start with a tidy-up? Some advice from someone with experience: those paper stacks tend to shrink after a little organization.

Enigma: Resorting to psychological suggestion?

Z: If it gets the job done.

Madam Z walks to the door, then turns to say goodbye.

Z: All in all, congratulations to you, Adler, and to Laplace.

Z: You've secured a positive future for this place.

She leaves. Enigma, standing surrounded by walls of files, sighs.

Marguerite: Enigma stops outside the meeting room door.

Enigma: Marguerite.

Laplace is a massive institution, and as such, they rarely cross paths. Last time, they'd exchanged only a brief nod.

He takes a moment to study her.

A cold, metallic gleam runs through the center of her dress, like a butterfly emerging from a dark cocoon of torn fabric and flesh.

Enigma: You ...

Enigma: I've seen your research. Not half bad.

She wears an impeccable smile.

Marguerite: Thank you, Mr. Adler.

Marguerite: And congratulations.

Brief, but sufficient.

He doesn't want his first act as director to be tearing an irreparable rift through Laplace.

Marguerite: Go on in, Mr. Adler. Everyone's waiting.

Crowd: Happy birthday!

Party poppers go off with a bang. Colorful ribbons rain down over Enigma.

Enigma: W-What the hell are you all doing?

None of this is what he'd expected.

It was supposed to be a brief meeting, but the moment he opened the door, control slipped away from him entirely.

X: It's a celebration, Mr. Enigma. For your birthday! And for your appointment as director, of course!

Enigma: Today isn't my birthday.

Hissabeth: Oh, that doesn't matter. You can celebrate it early.

Hissabeth: The most important thing is today is a day worth celebrating!

Snake I: Hiss, there's cake! Is that dairy cream, or something plant-based?

Hissabeth pulls another party popper. The sharp smell halts the snake's investigation.

Enigma: Wait ...

Ulrich: Our readings have shown higher concentrations of cortisol and adrenaline in the air.

Ulrich: We've all been under pressure lately. You most of all, Adler. Your index is higher than anyone else's.

Ulrich: A celebration like this gives everyone a chance to relax, which, in turn, will make them all the more productive with the upcoming workload.

A "thoughtful" theoretical justification for the party, courtesy of Ulrich.

Medicine Pocket: Well, this is a birthday party, isn't it? Make a wish, Enigma! What's that? You want me to make one on your behalf? Well, if you say so.

Medicine Pocket: I wish, more than anything in the world, for my approval form to pass today! I need to sample the outer material of the toybox.

Enigma: Denied! Your Picrasma consumption research already jumped the queue, and we need to maintain the structural integrity of the toybox.

Medicine Pocket rolls their eyes and drifts toward the toybox on the table anyway.

Enigma: Hey. Step away from the bo—no ...

This party seems to have given these geniuses an excuse to run wild.

No one cares anymore what the meeting was supposed to be about.

Enigma: Listen up!

He raises his voice, helpless.

And his brilliant colleagues finally spare him a moment of their attention.

Enigma: As you all know, I will be serving as Laplace's director.

X: Mmhmm?

X gives an approving whistle.

Hissabeth: No kidding! You don't say.

Ulrich: We were hardly surprised by the decision.

Ulrich: You'd already been doing the work for quite some time.

Ulrich: All this goes to prove that, even though you needed some time to adjust, Madam Lucy's judgment was correct.

Enigma: ...

Though he'd prepared a few words, he now finds himself thinking carefully about how a leader ought to express themselves.

Enigma: I suppose I've well and truly picked up some useless habits.

X: And? Anything else you want to say, Director?

He looks around at his colleagues.

Objectively speaking, they are all gifted, yet in wildly different ways.

Subjectively speaking, they are a handful.

Marguerite: But they all share the same belief—

Science.

He abandons the speech.

Enigma: In short, I will do my best.

Enigma: Until we find someone better suited for the job.

Enigma: Those who aren't taken by the "Storm"—where do they go when they die?

Enigma: A question that remains to be answered.

A black and white grid of a crossword puzzle.

Enigma: I don't believe in the existence of "gods." Nor in any heaven or hell.

Enigma: *sigh* I wish you could give me your answer, Greta.

Enigma: I wish I could ask you myself.

He rests his finger on the trigger.

Enigma: "Bang."

...

Hofmann: The age of humans has come to an end.

Hofmann: But you can continue living.

A fine pistol. A birthday gift.

A "memento."

A beginning.

Hofmann: In "our" new age.

An Unfinished Book

小径

Sequel

After that, the "Storm" brought the world to the 1990s.

Ms. Isolde readily accepted treatment. Ms. Kakania has been traveling the world, striving to change it. She quickly adapted to the new era and read many books. I also gave her plenty of recommendations.

It is worth noting that after the Vienna incident, Ms. Semmelweis became a vampire. This came as a massive surprise to everyone, but it also fascinated me—like reaching the payoff for a story's foreshadowing. After making many sincere requests, I got permission to read the beginning of her story. It is a complex tale, one that leaves you pondering incessantly about how it ends. However, if I were to retell the whole story here, this book would end up three times thicker. I would like to thank my mentor, Madam Hofmann, for showing me how to keep things concise in situations like this.

...

The world has traveled to 1920, but the war has not ended. It all feels like a continuation of that chaotic day. I heard Ms. Kakania was dejected the whole day, but she quickly returned to her mission from the Field Agent Administration. Even after crossing two eras, her tenacious spirit has not dampened at all. It seems that spirit has affected me, too: I find myself constantly thinking about what I can do. Thus, I have decided to write this book to organize my thoughts, in the hopes that I will find a conclusion before the final draft.

...

Researcher Onboarding Guide

小径

Beginner's Guide to Ciphers: Vigenère Edition

To prevent Laplace employees from falling victim to pranks from colleagues and to avoid research delays from being unable to break codes, we are distributing this Beginner's Guide to Ciphers: Vigenère Edition.
The Vigenère cipher can be seen as an upgrade to the Caesar cipher, turning the simple shift of a single alphabet into shifts across multiple alphabets to increase complexity. For more on the Caesar cipher, see the Caesar Cipher Edition.
The main difference between the Vigenère and Caesar ciphers is that in the Vigenère cipher, the relationship between the ciphertext and plaintext letters isn't one-to-one, making the key harder to figure out. However, since it still follows patterns, you can still find repeating ciphertext segments. By using high-frequency words in common language, you can guess the plaintext for specific segments of ciphertext, deduce the key length from the spacing between repeats, and analyze the key.
However, if you don't have much text, this can be difficult. In these situations, you should use other methods to guess the key. The personality, past, and writing habits of the person who made the code are important clues. Here is a list of people at Laplace who are very likely to play pranks with ciphers:

Adler, Ulrich, X, Richard, Dawkins, Victor ...

If you encounter a prank, consider these suspects first. If you can't crack the code, confront the suspects directly and ask them to stop the prank. If a suspect denies involvement, try to force them to decode it for you. It doesn't matter whether they're really the culprit or not.

Dress Code

小径

Notice on Today's Party

To everyone on the Space Monitor Project team:
There's a celebration party this Saturday! Don't forget to wear your best clothes! —Hissabeth

Medicine Pocket has invented a new Picrasma Candy dessert! It has a beautiful circular shape! Everyone is welcome to try it! —37

Due to a venue conflict, this week's "Nautika Meet-and-Greet" has been moved from Saturday 15:00 - 17:00 to Friday at the same time. —Ezra

The study On Picrasma as a Coffee Substitute Safe for Human Consumption has been uploaded to the database. —X

Ms. Windsong is taking me out to buy proper clothes for the party. The office will be empty today from 14:00 to 18:00. Please don't make a wasted trip. —Kiperina

... I didn't expect it to be so formal. Alright, I will be there on time. —Name Day

My appointment as director of the LSCC will officially take effect this Saturday. —Adler

Regarding the Space Monitor Project team's celebration party, just remember to come. The dress code is just another one of Sylvie's flights of fancy. —Pointer